

Adopted West Somerset Local Plan to 2032

November 2016

WEST SOMERSET LOCAL PLAN: ADOPTION

Resolutions in Minute C.59 of West Somerset Council meeting of Full Council on 23rd November 2016

RESOLVED (1) that the West Somerset Local Plan to 2032 be adopted incorporating:

- (i) the modifications as indicated in the Appendix to the Inspector's Report,
- (ii) the Additional Modifications, unchanged, which were consulted on between 3 June and 15 July 2016, and,
- (iii) a renumbering of some of the policies within it for reasons of consistency and clarity.

RESOLVED (2) that the continued use of the extant policies in the West Somerset District Local Plan – Adopted, April 2006 that have not been identified for replacement by the West Somerset Local Plan to 2032 be endorsed.

RESOLVED (3) that the continued use of the Planning Obligations Supplementary Planning Document as a statement of Council policy for the West Somerset Local Planning Authority area be endorsed.

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1.0 INTRODUCTION

1.1. Introduction

The Local Plan for West Somerset aims to help make West Somerset a better place to live in, go to school in, do business in, retire in and also where people can enjoy life. The Local Plan's policies, created with the involvement of the area's communities, will help to guide the sustainable development of the parts of West Somerset District outside the Exmoor National Park.

In order to provide the housing and other development which the area needs to maintain thriving communities and economy the Local Plan's approach will be to find ways of saying 'yes' rather than 'no' to development unless the sustainability principles of the plan are compromised.

1.2 The legal requirement to prepare a Local Plan, and the change of the title of the document from 'Core Strategy' to 'Local Plan'.

The Localism Act 2011¹ requires the Council to prepare a Local Plan, the associated Local Planning Regulations² set out how it must go about doing this. The Localism Act changed the previous title of "Core Strategy" to "Local Plan" accordingly all references to the Core Strategy apart from this explanatory paragraph, or references to documents from previous stages in the process, have been changed to "Local Plan". It must be stressed that the Council is continuing with the preparation of essentially the same document. Once adopted, the Local Plan will have powerful planning policies which form part of the statutory Development Plan for the area.

The new West Somerset Local Plan covering the period from 2012 to 2032 should not be confused with the old West Somerset District Local Plan adopted in 2006,³ whose saved policies continue to have some influence on development as a material consideration where they do not conflict with the National Planning Policy Framework. The old plan, where referred to in this document will be known as the "saved West Somerset District Local Plan".

1.3 Localism, Neighbourhood Planning and the Local Plan

The Local Plan's importance has increased with the passage of the Localism Act 2011⁴ and the publication of the National Planning Policy Framework, which have enabled the abolition of Regional Spatial Strategies and all national housing targets as well as saved structure plan policies. This means that the Local Plan must set out a strategy for the area which is justified by the evidence in the context of the National Planning Policy Framework. This in turn will provide a context for the preparation of Neighbourhood Development Plans.

1.4 A presumption in favour of sustainable development:

The National Planning Policy Framework⁵ includes a presumption in favour of sustainable development as the driver of the planning system. Accordingly, the Local Plan sets out a vision for the sustainable development of the District's

communities over the next 20 years and provides the means of achieving it through the application of strategic planning policies.

The Local Plan does not provide a detailed set of development control policies like those in the saved West Somerset District Local Plan.⁶ Many of the saved West Somerset District Local Plan's policies will remain of material importance until replaced by new adopted planning policies either in the new Local Plan or other future planning policy documents. The Local Plan will provide a context for other planning policy documents which will assist with the implementation of the Local Plan's vision.

1.5 Preparing the Local Plan - A brief outline of the Local Plan preparation process:

- Gathering evidence about the area covered by the Local Plan through a mix of existing data and commissioned studies to inform and justify strategy / policies.
- Formal announcement of the preparation of the document to the community as well as statutory and non-statutory consultees as well as a consultation exercise to identify the key issues affecting the area, which the document's policies will have to address.
- Input the aims and objectives of the Community Strategy for the area and the Council's corporate objectives.
- Preparation of sustainability appraisal objectives and baseline study – subject to consultation with the Government's statutory advisors (English Heritage, Natural England and the Environment Agency).
- The identification of a Local Plan vision, key and critical issues, strategic objectives and a series of strategy options which are tested both through community and stakeholder engagement as well as through the application of Sustainability Appraisal.
- A Preferred Strategy is produced embodying the most favourable option as identified through the process outlined above; this is subject to community and stakeholder engagement.
- Following consideration of responses to the consultation on the Preferred Strategy and any necessary amendments, the Local Plan is formally published, and then submitted to the Secretary of State for examination. Following the receipt of the Inspector's Report the document will be adopted by the Council with any appropriate amendments.

(IMPORTANT - This is not a full description of the Local Plan preparation process, for which reference should be made to the Town and Country

Planning (Local Planning) (England) Regulations 2012⁷ as amended, as well as the National Planning Policy Framework and the National Planning Practice Guidance).⁸

1.6 Community engagement:

Community engagement is being carried out in accordance with the Council's adopted Statement of Community Involvement⁹ as amended by subsequent changes to the Regulations. This has involved a range of methods, and using both formal and informal consultation exercises.

2.0 A SPATIAL PORTRAIT OF THE WEST SOMERSET LOCAL PLAN AREA

2.1 Apart from the three main settlements, services are relatively thinly spread amongst the rural communities. A large, thinly populated hinterland looks mainly to the relatively self-contained main settlements of Minehead / Alcombe, Watchet and Williton for its everyday services. In the southern and eastern fringes of the Local Plan area communities also look to Taunton, Wiveliscombe, Bridgwater, Dulverton and Tiverton. The propensity to use various service centres relates, to a significant degree, to the varying quality of the road network and the relative ease with which they can be reached. Whilst villages tend to have a minor role in terms of service provision (if any), most do have at least a village hall. In terms of sustainable development principles, it is the community and cultural life of the District which relies heavily on the village communities because a substantial minority of the Local Plan area's population lives in the villages.

2.2 Location and population:

West Somerset District lies on the north coast of the south west peninsula between North Devon and Sedgemoor Districts. More than half of the District's area is within the Exmoor National Park (which has its own local planning authority). About three quarters of West Somerset's 34,675 population¹⁰ (ONS 2011 Census of Population) lives within the area for which this Local Plan is being prepared, outside the National Park. The West Somerset Local Plan to 2032 area extent plan (Fig 1) shows the Local Plan area including the larger settlements and parish boundaries. About two thirds of the Local Plan area's population (c.18,000 out of c.27,000 people) live on or near the coast in the three main settlements of Minehead / Alcombe, Watchet and Williton.

A marked characteristic of the area's demographic profile is the unusually high proportion of elderly people compared with the national average.

2.3 The Local Plan area Comprises:

- a coastal zone between Minehead in the west and Steart Peninsula in the east,
- the north western part of the Quantock Hills, notable for its exposed, moorland character,
- to the south, part of the Brendon Hills and
- A further, detached southern area at Brushford in the Barle Valley to the south of Exmoor.

The area's geography is complex ranging from the coastal levels, parts of which are vulnerable to sea flooding between Blue Anchor and Minehead and at the Steart Peninsula, and the Brendon and Quantock Hills rising to over 300 metres.

2.4 How the settlements relate to each other and the surrounding area:

- The largest settlement is the Victorian seaside resort town of Minehead with 11,981 population¹¹ together with the smaller adjacent settlement of Alcombe. It is the main service centre in the District, having a community hospital, a community college, middle school and a substantial shopping centre. It is also the location of a Butlins holiday centre, which in the peak holiday season is home to up to c.6,000 visitors at a time. Its service centre role relates to a wider area including much of Exmoor and parts of North Devon.
- There are two other settlements with a significant secondary service provision role beyond their immediate area: the historic port of Watchet (3,785 population¹²) and the nearby rural service centre village of Williton (2,602 population¹³) which is also the location of the West Somerset Council's main offices.
- As well as relying on Minehead, the southern extremity of the Local Plan area around Brushford looks to nearby Dulverton in the National Park and also the more distant larger centre of Tiverton.
- Villages and hamlets in the eastern part of the Brendon Hills look to Wiveliscombe for local services.
- Crowcombe and Stogumber tend to look to Taunton for their services
- Villages to the east of the Quantocks look mainly towards Bridgwater for their services.

2.5 West Somerset settlement transport and access:

The growth of the main settlements has been substantially influenced by the development of modes of transport over the years. Watchet and Minehead grew initially because of their accessibility from the sea; Minehead only took on its status as the main settlement in the area following the extension of the railway from Taunton to the town in 1874¹⁴ and development of the town's tourism industry. Since the motor vehicle became the dominant means of transport in the years after 1945 the nature of the road network has influenced the function of settlements. Williton sits at the junction of the two major road links in West Somerset, the A39 from Minehead to Bridgwater, and the A358 from Taunton to Williton. Neither of these are trunk roads, they are both relatively narrow A roads. The A39 is restricted by a number of pinch points such as that at Kilve, where two HGVs cannot pass each other, whilst the A358 is constrained by three limited headroom railway bridges. These roads serve the settlements in the coastal strip and on both sides of the Quantock Hills. The remaining inland parts of the Local Plan area, on the Brendon Hills and the Brushford area are relatively poorly accessed via the A396 south from Dunster or by the B roads over the top of the Brendon Hills via Raleigh's Cross.

Minehead lies some 25 miles / 45 minutes' drive from M5 J25 at Taunton via the A358 and A39 and 27 miles / 50 minutes' drive from M5 J24 at Bridgwater via the A39. At peak hours these timings increase significantly. Journey times to settlements away from the main roads increase considerably depending on the additional distance involved. Many parts of the minor road network, besides being narrow and winding, are severely constrained by the local geography and a lack of good road links between some parts of the District.

The use of walking as a means of transport is inhibited in some of the local settlements by the lack of safe footways in key locations. Minehead however has a good level of access to its services and facilities by a range of transport modes including walking and cycling.

2.6 The West Somerset Local Plan area and neighbouring Housing Market Areas

The District lies within two overlapping housing market areas:

The Taunton and South Somerset HMA (T&SSHMA):¹⁵

- 'Taunton' and 'South Somerset' were treated as two separate HMAs in the study due to their relatively self-contained nature. West Somerset is treated as part of the Taunton HMA. This showed that whilst there was a high overall degree of self-containment within the HMA in relation to the main centres of employment, Taunton and Bridgwater (a 70% travel to work self-containment level), this applied rather less in West Somerset where there was more internal self-containment focused on Minehead.
- West Somerset's population is mainly concentrated in the coastal area settlements. These relate most strongly to Taunton, Bridgwater and to a lesser extent Tiverton in terms of housing market, employment and higher level service provision. The thinly populated area of Exmoor to the south and west of Minehead, which has a poor highway network, extends into Devon creating a barrier to service access in that direction.

The Northern Peninsula HMA (NPSHMA):¹⁶

- The Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula provides a more detailed reflection of West Somerset's housing market. Outside the HMA links to the rest of Somerset and the Bristol housing market are stated to be stronger than those with the Exeter housing market.¹⁷
- A further marked characteristic is the strength of connections with distant housing markets – in particular those in London, the South East and East of England, and the West Midlands. Moves to the Northern Peninsula

- HMA are particularly strong for families with dependent children, people in middle age and early retirees.¹⁸ These connections, particularly with the higher value housing markets of the south east, are a significant driver of increasing local property values and increasing proportion of over 50s in the West Somerset population.
- A review of the Northern Peninsula Strategic Housing Market Assessment was recently carried out in order to ensure that the provisions of the NPPF regarding housing requirements are properly fulfilled in the light of up to date evidence.¹⁹
- Due to events elsewhere in the country it has been necessary to commission a limited review of the NPSHMA taking into account the latest DCLG population projections for 2012. This work has been commissioned jointly with the other Northern Peninsula HMP partner Local Planning Authorities.²⁰

2.7 Land use and economy:

- The majority of the Local Plan area's economic activity is located in the coastal strip.
- Most of the District is in agricultural or forestry use, pastoral farming being a particularly substantial part. The two major sources of employment within the District are agriculture and tourism, in particular the Butlins holiday centre in Minehead.
- Nuclear power generation at Hinkley Point is also a significant employer with c.600 workers at the existing power station. This is likely to increase significantly in the future assuming that the proposed development of the Hinkley Point C power station proceeds.
- As a consequence of the age profile of the District, social care is also a growing employment sector, like tourism and farming it is not particularly well paid.
- The District's other major tourist attraction is the substantially volunteer run West Somerset Steam Railway running for over 20 miles between Bishop's Lydeard near Taunton and its western terminus in Minehead linking the three largest settlements in the District by rail for much of the year. It should be noted that due to the nature of the railway it does not provide a commuter service. Notwithstanding this, it has been recently used on a number of occasions for revenue earning through freight services from Network Rail carrying very substantial loads of rock for coastal protection purposes.

2.8 Drainage and flooding:

Much of the Local Plan area drains through short, relatively steep catchments to the Bristol Channel, however there is land in the south and east of the area which drains into either the Exe or Parrett catchments respectively. Each of the main three settlements has areas affected by a high risk of flooding either from local watercourses, and in the case of Minehead and Watchet, also from the sea. The issue of flood risk in planning for new development will be an important task for the Local Plan.

2.9 Landscape protection and biodiversity:

A substantial part of the Local Plan area borders onto the Exmoor National Park,²¹ within which the landscape is subject to statutory protection. The part of the Quantock Hills within the Local Plan area is designated as an Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty²² which is also protected. There are a number of significant areas protected as Natura 2000 sites under the 1992 European Community Habitats Directive²³ for their ecological value as well as nationally designated Sites of Special Scientific Interest.²⁴

2.10 Hinkley Point nuclear power station:

The existing Hinkley Point nuclear power station lies within the north-eastern part of the District. Whilst Hinkley Point A is currently being decommissioned, Hinkley Point B remains an operational power station. A Development Consent Order was granted by Parliament in March 2013 for the development of Hinkley Point C power station with two new nuclear reactors.²⁵ Assuming that the project proceeds, it would constitute the largest investment in the District for many years, and would involve the influx of a substantial additional workforce (with an estimated peak of c.5600 workers) over a period of several years. Most site workers living to the south of West Somerset would be expected to use the B3190 from Bampton to Watchet in order to access the Smithyard park and ride site near Williton having left the M5 at Junction 27.

3.0 THE EVIDENCE BASE

- 3.1** The policies of the Local Plan are justified by the evidence gathered together with data already available on the area and its characteristics so that it should be found legally sound when examined. The NPPF advises that local plans should be based on: "...adequate, up-to-date and relevant evidence about the economic, social and environmental characteristics and prospects of the area. Local planning authorities should ensure that their assessment of and strategies for housing, employment and other uses are integrated, and that they take full account of relevant market and economic signals."

The evidence base consists of two elements:

- Evidence of community and stakeholder participation in the preparation of the Local Plan, and; Research setting out factual evidence which underpins the vision, objectives and policies of the Local Plan.

3.2 The evidence base research studies which have been prepared are:

- Taunton and South Somerset Housing Market Areas Strategic Housing Market Assessments 2008;²⁶
- The Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula 2008;²⁷
- Northern Peninsula Strategic Housing Market Assessment: West Somerset Update – November 2013²⁸
- Northern Peninsula Housing Market Area Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA) Update: Final Report – January 2015²⁹
- Somerset Gypsy and Traveller Accommodation Assessment (jointly with other Somerset LPA's) ³⁰
- Gypsy and Traveller Needs Assessment Update 2013³¹
- West Somerset Strategic Housing Land Availability Assessment;³²
- West Somerset Employment Land Review; ³³
- Level 1 Strategic Flood Risk Assessment (jointly with the Exmoor National Park Authority)³⁴
- Level 2 Strategic Flood Risk Assessment (for areas where pressure for strategic development exists);³⁵
- West Somerset Town Centre Uses Study (jointly with the Exmoor National Park Authority);³⁶
- West Somerset Council LPA Historic Environment Issues Paper³⁷
- West Somerset Renewable Energy Potential Study³⁸
- West Somerset Sport and Recreation Study³⁹
- The West Somerset Economic Strategy 2009⁴⁰ & 2011⁴¹

4.0 THE KEY ISSUES IDENTIFIED DURING THE PLAN PREPARATION PROCESS

4.1 Housing and Community:

- The provision of significantly more affordable housing
- Providing appropriate facilities for the older people amongst the District's population (relating particularly to appropriate housing provision),
- Improved provision of sport and recreation facilities
- Fuel poverty (resulting from a high proportion of properties without access to mains gas, and a high proportion of houses which are difficult to heat)
- Providing an appropriate level of facilities for young people
- Meeting the challenge of the impacts of the new nuclear proposals at Hinkley Point

4.2 Settlement hierarchy and development distribution:

- Identifying a hierarchy of settlements within West Somerset in terms of their functions
- The need to maintain and increase the self-containment of West Somerset settlements
- The identification of the most appropriate locations for new development

4.3 Transport:

- Increasing the proportion of non-private car travel within the District
- Improving accessibility to and from West Somerset

4.4 Employment / Business / Tourism:

- Promoting tourism and in particular more sustainable tourism
- Increasing the amount of, and broadening the variety of employment opportunities within the District, particularly the knowledge based, high income sector
- Continuing to encourage appropriate training and educational opportunities locally
- The importance of the agricultural industry to the area and its contribution to sustainable food production
- The need to retain more young people within the community (19 to 45 age group particularly)

4.5 Climate Change:

- The management of flood risk
- The efficient use of water supplies
- Encouraging the creation of a low / zero carbon economy
- Mitigating the effects of climate change

4.6 Historic and Natural Heritage protection:

- Protecting the landscape and built heritage of West Somerset

- Protection of the environment
- Protecting and strengthening biodiversity within the District

4.7 Other key issues:

- Co-ordinating policy development with the Exmoor National Park Authority

4.8 The critical issues for the Local Plan area:

These are the challenges which really stand out, the successful management of which provides the key to addressing other key issues and enabling positive place shaping to take place within the plan area. This is the essential purpose for preparing a Local Plan. The Critical Issues are:

1. Mitigating the effects of the Hinkley Point C new nuclear proposals;
2. The extreme degree of disparity between average house prices and average earnings, with consequent high level of unmet affordable housing need;
3. The need to provide c. 2,900 dwellings during the period 2012 to 2032;
4. The demographic imbalance in the area, with its low proportion of 19 – 45 year olds, and high proportion of 50+ age group;
5. The narrow base of the economy, and the predominance of low income jobs in agriculture, tourism and social care;
6. Poor level of accessibility between the West Somerset communities and the M5 corridor;
7. Reducing the relatively high per capita level of CO² production within West Somerset;
8. Management of flood risk in and around the main settlements, and;
9. The importance of protecting the West Somerset landscape.

These critical issues are also the driving force for the themes and objectives of the Somerset and West Somerset Sustainable Community Strategies^{42, 43} and also the Council's Corporate Plan.⁴⁴

5.0 THE SPATIAL VISION FOR WEST SOMERSET SHOWING HOW THE AREA AND THE PLACES IN IT SHOULD DEVELOP:

- 5.1 ECONOMY** - By 2032 the area's main service and employment centre: Minehead / Alcombe, the secondary service and employment centres of Watchet and Williton and rural employment sites such as Brushford / Dulverton will be the centres of a thriving and increasingly varied local economy within West Somerset, aided by the provision of super-fast optical broadband access, all of which will enable more people to work close to, or in their homes. People will have the skills to enable them to work and thrive in this more diverse economy. The tourism industry will also have diversified with a wider range of sustainable enterprises. The Hinkley Point C new nuclear project will have been completed having brought considerable economic stimulus to the area whilst the temporary adverse impacts of the construction phase should be in the past.
- 5.2 HOUSING** – By 2032 there will have been a significant increase in the amount of affordable housing provided in the area. More people will be able to afford housing which is appropriate to their circumstances. New housing development will have been delivered in locations which will help to secure a reduction in transport demand and more self-contained settlements. About 2,900 additional houses will have been provided in the Local Plan area, the largest part of these being provided at Minehead / Alcombe.
- 5.3 ENVIRONMENT** – By 2032 there will be a marked increase in the low carbon economy locally. Biodiversity will have been strengthened and flood risk will have been managed positively in accommodating new development. More of the District's food supply will be produced locally.

6.0 STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES FOR WEST SOMERSET FOCUSING ON THE KEY ISSUES TO BE ADDRESSED:

6.1 Strategic objectives for the area based on the key issues⁴⁵ identified in the initial Regulation 18⁴⁶ consultation exercise:

- Strengthening the roles and functions of Minehead as the District's main service centre, and Watchet and Williton as secondary service centres.
- Implementation of types and quantities of development in locations appropriate to meet the requirements of the Strategy based on the evidence and engagement.
- Increase self-containment within Minehead, Watchet and Williton.
- successfully managing flood risk in implementing new development at Minehead Watchet and Williton
- Make a step change in the provision of affordable housing to meet identified local needs
- Make a significant reduction in CO² emissions for the Local Plan area.
- Create an aspirational, enterprising and entrepreneurial culture within West Somerset
- Develop the quality of the tourism offer within the Local Plan area
- Protect and enhance biodiversity in the Local Plan area
- Conserve and enhance the character of historic settlements, buildings and landscapes
- Deliver high quality design in new development which will contribute to the area's heritage in a positive way.

References for Sections 1 – 6

1.0 INTRODUCTION

- ¹ H.M. Government; Localism Act 2011, Chapter 20 (as amended); The Stationary Office; 2011; ISBN 978 0 10 542011 8
- ² H.M. Government; The Town and Country Planning (Local Planning) (England) Regulations 2012 - Statutory Instrument 2012 No.767 (S.I. 2012:767); The Stationary Office; 2012; ISBN 978 0 11 152192 2
- ³ West Somerset District Council; West Somerset District Local Plan – Adopted April 2006; West Somerset District Council; 2008.
- ⁴ H.M. Government; Localism Act 2011, Chapter 20 (as amended); op. cit.
- ⁵ Department for Communities and Local Government; National Planning Policy Framework – March 2012 ; Department for Communities and Local Government; 2012; ISBN 978 1 4098 3413 7
- ⁶ West Somerset District Council; West Somerset District Local Plan – Adopted April 2006; op. cit.
- ⁷ H.M. Government; The Town and Country Planning (Local Planning) (England) Regulations 2012 - Statutory Instrument 2012 No.767 (S.I. 2012:767); op. cit.
- ⁸ Department of Communities and Local Government; National Planning Policy Framework – National Planning Practice Guidance (as amended); Department for Communities and Local Government Planning Portal (web-site <http://planningguidance.planningportal.gov.uk/>); 2014.
- ⁹ West Somerset Council; West Somerset Core Strategy Statement of Community Involvement: Adopted, December 2014; West Somerset Council; 2014.

2.0 A SPATIAL PORTRAIT OF THE WEST SOMERSET LOCAL PLAN AREA

- ¹⁰ Office for National Statistics; Census 2011: Neighbourhood Statistics: West Somerset Local Authority: Key Statistics; Office for National Statistics; 2013. (data-set at, www.neighbourhood.statistics.gov.uk)
- ¹¹ Office for National Statistics; Census 2011: Neighbourhood Statistics: Area – Minehead (Parish): Key Statistics; Office for National Statistics; 2013.
- ¹² Office for National Statistics; Census 2011: Neighbourhood Statistics: Area – Watchet (Parish): Key Statistics; Office for National Statistics; 2013.
- ¹³ Office for National Statistics; Census 2011: Neighbourhood Statistics: Area – Williton (Parish): Key Statistics; Office for National Statistics; 2013.
- ¹⁴ Minehead Railway Company; The Minehead Railway Act 1871; H.M.S.O.; 1871.
- ¹⁵ Fordham Research; Taunton and South Somerset Housing Market Areas Strategic Housing Market Assessments: Final Report – February 2009; Taunton and South Somerset Areas Strategic Housing Market Partnership; 2009.
- ¹⁶ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula – December 2008; Northern Peninsula Housing Market Partnership; 2008
- ¹⁷ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula – December 2008: Executive Summary; Northern Peninsula Housing Market Partnership; 2008 (para. 2.2 page vii)

- ¹⁸ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula – December 2008: Executive Summary; Northern Peninsula Housing Market Partnership; 2008 (para. 2.3 page vii)
- ¹⁹ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment: West Somerset Update - Final Report, November 2013; West Somerset Council; 2013.
- ²⁰ Housing Vision; Northern Peninsula Housing Market Area Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA) Update: Final Report – January 2015; Northern Peninsula Strategic Housing Market Partnership; 2015
- ²¹ H.M. Government; National Parks and Access to the Countryside Act 1949: Exmoor National Park (Designation) Order 1954 (HLG 92/176); HMSO; 1954.
- ²² H.M. Government ; National Parks and Access to the Countryside Act 1949: Quantock Hills Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty (Designation) Order 1956; HMSO; 1956
- ²³ European Economic Community; Council Directive 92/43/EEC of 21st May 1992 on the Conservation of Natural Habitats and of Wild Fauna and Flora (as amended); European Economic Community; 1992
- ²⁴ H.M. Government; The Wildlife and Countryside Act 1981, Chapter 69 (as amended); HMSO; 1981; ISBN 978 0 10 546981 0
- ²⁵ H.M. Government; Infrastructure Planning: The Hinkley Point C (Nuclear Generating Station) Order 2013 – Statutory Instrument 2013 No.648 (S.I. 2013:648); The Stationary Office; 2013; ISBN 978 0 11 153278 2.
- 3.0 THE EVIDENCE BASE**
- ²⁶ Fordham Research; Taunton and South Somerset Housing Market Areas Strategic Housing Market Assessments: Final Report – February 2009; op. cit.
- ²⁷ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment for the Northern Peninsula – December 2008; op. cit.
- ²⁸ Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment: West Somerset Update – Final Report - November 2013; West Somerset Council; 2013.
- ²⁹ Housing Vision; Northern Peninsula Housing Market Area Strategic Housing Market Assessment (SHMA) Update: Final Report – January 2015; Northern Peninsula Strategic Housing Market Partnership; 2015
- ³⁰ De Montfort University; Somerset Gypsy and Traveller Accommodation Assessment – Final Report, October 2010; Somerset Strategic Housing Market Partnership; 2010.
- ³¹ De Montfort University; Somerset Local Planning Authorities Gypsy and Traveller Needs Assessment Update: Final Report – October 2013; Somerset Strategic Housing Market Partnership; 2013.
- ³² Hunter Page Planning Ltd.; West Somerset District Council Strategic Housing Land Availability Assessment – March 2010; West Somerset Council; 2010.
- ³³ Hunter Page Planning Ltd.; Employment Land Review: Report Stages 1 – 3, May 2009 – April 2010; West Somerset Council; 2010.
- ³⁴ Scott Wilson; West Somerset Council & Exmoor National Park Authority Strategic Flood Risk Assessment Level 1: Final Report – March 2009; West Somerset Council; 2009
- ³⁵ Scott Wilson; West Somerset Council Level 2 Strategic Flood Risk Assessment: Final Report – October 2010; West Somerset Council; 2010

³⁶ Todd, Stuart; West Somerset Local Planning Authority Area Town and Village Centres Study – November 2011; West Somerset Council; 2012.

³⁷ Somerset County Council, Historic Environment Service; West Somerset Council Local Planning Authority Historic Environment Issues Paper – April 2014; West Somerset Council; 2014

³⁸ Stuart Todd Associates; West Somerset Local Planning Authority Area Renewable and Low Carbon Energy Potential Study – September 2011; West Somerset Council; 2012.

³⁹ Stuart Todd Associates; West Somerset Council Local Planning Authority Sport and Recreation Facilities Study – March 2012; West Somerset Council; 2012.

⁴⁰ EKOS Consulting; The West Somerset Economic Strategy: Delivering the Equilibrium – April 2009; West Somerset Council; 2009.

⁴¹ ARUP; West Somerset Economic Strategy Refresh: Responding to Change: Draft Strategy Document – August 2011; West Somerset Council; 2011.

4.0 THE KEY ISSUES IDENTIFIED DURING THE PLAN PREPARATION PROCESS.

⁴² Somerset Strategic Partnership; Somerset, a Landscape for the Future: Sustainable Community Strategy for Somerset 2008 – 2026; Somerset County Council; 2009.

⁴³ West Somerset Strategic Partnership; West Somerset Sustainable Community Strategy 2007 – 2010; West Somerset Council; 2007.

⁴⁴ West Somerset Council; West Somerset Council Corporate Plan 2013 – 16; West Somerset Council; 2013.

5.0 THE SPATIAL VISION FOR WEST SOMERSET SHOWING HOW THE AREA AND THE PLACES IN IT SHOULD DEVELOP:

6.0 STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES FOR WEST SOMERSET FOCUSING ON THE KEY ISSUES TO BE ADDRESSED:

⁴⁵ West Somerset Council; West Somerset Core Strategy Options Paper – January 2010; West Somerset Council; 2010 (Section 3.0, p.6)

⁴⁶ H.M. Government; The Town and Country Planning (Local Planning) (England) Regulations 2012 - Statutory Instrument 2012 No.767 (S.I. 2012:767); op. cit.

THE LOCAL PLAN POLICIES

SUSTAINABILITY

POLICY SD1:

PRESUMPTION IN FAVOUR OF SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

When considering development proposals the decision maker will take a positive approach that reflects the presumption in favour of sustainable development contained in the national planning policy framework. It will always work proactively with applicants jointly to find solutions which mean that proposals can be approved wherever possible, and to secure development that improves the economic, social, historic and natural environmental conditions in the area.

Planning applications that accord with the policies in this local plan (and, where relevant, with policies in neighbourhood plans) will be approved without delay, unless material considerations indicate otherwise.

Where there are no policies relevant to the application or relevant policies are out of date at the time of making the decision then the decision maker will grant permission unless material considerations indicate otherwise – taking into account whether:

- any adverse impacts of granting permission would significantly and demonstrably outweigh the benefits, when assessed against the policies in the national planning policy framework taken as a whole; or
- specific policies in that framework indicate that development should be restricted.

Purpose

- o This draft policy, provided by the Planning Inspectorate, articulates the National Planning Policy Framework's (NPPF's) emphasis on the requirement for all development to contribute towards the objectives of sustainable development and embeds it in the Local Plan.
- o Sustainable development is seen as having three distinct roles; economic, social and, environmental, as far as the NPPF is concerned. It is defined for the purposes of this plan as follows:
 - **Economic** – contributing to building a strong, responsive and competitive economy, by ensuring that sufficient land of the right type, and in the right places, is available in the right places at the right time to support growth and innovation; and by identifying and coordinating development

requirements, including the provision of infrastructure;

- **Social** – supporting strong, vibrant and healthy communities, by providing the supply of housing required to meet the needs of present and future generations; and by creating a high quality built environment, with accessible local services that reflect the community's needs and supports its health, social and cultural wellbeing; and
 - **Environmental** – contributing to protecting and enhancing our natural, built and historic environment; and as part of this, helping to improve biodiversity, use natural resources prudently, minimise waste and pollution and mitigate and adapt to climate change, including moving to a low-carbon economy.
- o The Local Plan seeks to encourage and manage development throughout the Local Planning Authority area in a way that supports sustainable patterns of movement and interaction of communities, the individuals within them, and, visitors to the area. Development proposals will be supported throughout the area where they accord with the overall strategy of focusing it in the preferred locations set out in other policies within the Local Plan. Development proposals that do not accord with the strategy and policies will be considered provided that it can be demonstrated that;
- there is a need for the development in that location, and,
 - It cannot be sited elsewhere in a more sustainable location

Such proposals would be expected to provide detailed evidence and a clear justification as to how they meet the terms of these criteria.

Assumptions

- o Providing the land and policies to deliver the development types required in various places to allow the economy and local communities to fulfil their potential will provide good outcomes for the community in terms of the protection of its environment, the prosperity of its population and the convenience and utility of the facilities they are able to enjoy within a reasonable distance of their homes.

Justification

- o The inclusion of the policy is a requirement of the NPPF. The policies included in the draft preferred strategy aim to deliver the development which is needed to maximise the self-containment of the main settlements, whilst allowing the larger villages to continue to have a modest amount of development proportionate to their size and available facilities.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17 and, 120

POLICY EN1: MITIGATION OF IMPACT OF HINKLEY POINT NUCLEAR PROPOSALS

Proposals for the mitigation of impacts arising from the development of a new nuclear power station at Hinkley Point must demonstrate that:

- **they respect the positive economic and social characteristics of communities affected especially those neighbouring them, that;**
- **adequate measures are taken to mitigate the adverse cultural, economic, environmental and social impact of the related development, (both temporary and permanent and, preparatory and ancillary) on the communities affected, both in the short and the longer term, and that;**
- **they respect the local natural environment in which they are located.**

Purpose

- o The policy requires that appropriate mitigation of adverse impacts and the optimisation of beneficial impacts arising from the Hinkley Point new nuclear development proposals is provided.
- o This policy does not apply to development covered by the NSIP process and to which the DCO applies.

Assumptions

- o That a construction project on the scale of a new nuclear power station in a remote rural location will bring a wide range of impacts, both positive and negative.
- o Some of these impacts will be on a very significant scale,
- o They will range in timescale between short and long term.

Justification

The Department of Energy and Climate Change (DECC) has identified the need to upgrade the energy generation capacity and associated infrastructure within the UK and make provision for a more secure system of supply in order to meet the existing and future demands for energy. Energy from nuclear sources is seen as making a valuable contribution to the anticipated future demand. Hinkley Point has been a focus of nuclear power generation development since 1957 and has been identified as a suitable location for a new generation of nuclear power supply. Following an Examination in Public by an independent Panel from the Infrastructure Planning Commission (IPC)/Major Infrastructure Planning Unit (MIPU) and a recommendation to the Secretary of State of Energy & Climate Change, a decision letter was issued on 19th March 2013.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 1, 28, 48, 61, 79, 80, 113 and, 120.

SPATIAL STRATEGY

POLICY SC1: HIERARCHY OF SETTLEMENTS

- 1. New development will be concentrated in the district's main centre, Minehead/Alcombe, and in the rural service centres of Watchet and Williton, this will be on a scale generally proportionate to their respective roles and functions to their own communities and those in surrounding settlements that rely on their larger neighbours for essential services and facilities.**
- 2. Limited development in the primary villages: Bicknoller, Carhampton, Crowcombe, Kilve, Stogumber, Stogursey, West Quantoxhead and Washford, will be permitted where it can be demonstrated that it will contribute to wider sustainability benefits for the area.**
- 3. At the secondary villages: Holford, Dunster Marsh, Brompton Ralph, Battleton and, Brushford, small scale development will be permitted where it can be demonstrated that it will contribute to wider sustainability benefits for the area.**
- 4. Development within or in close proximity (within 50 metres) to the contiguous built-up area of Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet, Williton and primary and secondary villages will only be considered where it can be demonstrated that:**
 - A. It is well related to existing essential services and social facilities within the settlement, and;**
 - B. There is safe and easy pedestrian access to the essential services and social facilities within the settlement, and;**
 - C. It respects the historic environment and complements the character of the existing settlement, and;**
 - D. It does not generate significant additional traffic movements over minor roads to and from the national primary and county highway route network**
 - E. It does not harm the amenity of the area or the adjoining land uses.**

Development elsewhere in the open countryside will be considered under Policy OC1.

Purpose

- o The policy seeks to achieve a beneficial distribution of new development within the Local Plan area, so as to maintain or strengthen the current service roles and functions of the various settlements.
- o The policy provides clear guidance about the appropriate scale and location of new development within the Local Plan area.

Assumptions

- o Directing new development proportionately to the area's larger settlements which currently provide most of the retail, employment, education and other service facilities within the area will help to maintain and enhance their attractiveness to service providers.
- o This will help to maximise the number of trips to service destinations which are completed within the local area and, particularly, within the main settlements.
- o The number of service sector jobs provided in the local area will also be maintained or increased.
- o Quality of life benefits will be experienced by the local population through maintaining or improving the range of services which are available within the local area.

Justification

- o The West Somerset Town Centre Study details the type and location of town centre uses across the Local Plan area.
- o The majority of town centre uses within the area are located in Minehead/Alcombe, which serves a wider area including a large part of the Exmoor National Park.
- o Historically approximately 80% of new development within the Local Plan area has taken place at the area's main service centre of Minehead/ Alcombe, and the secondary service centres of Watchet and Williton. This pattern of development has served to sustain a good level of local services in these three settlements. Maintaining this pattern of development should continue to support the health of the service functions of the three main settlements. This is likely to require some adjustment to their development limits.
- o Village based services have shown a tendency to decline over time, with the loss of many local shops, post offices, pubs and petrol filling stations. This is partly a result of greater mobility arising from higher levels of private car ownership and use, and the greater choice offered by services accessible in larger settlements. Development of an appropriate scale in villages can help to secure the range of services and employment opportunities available in the

villages.

- o The continuing health and sustainability of villages was identified as an important issue in the Taylor Report. A balance must be reached by means of which a modest amount of new development including both affordable and market housing can help to secure the future of these settlements. Such development should be limited according to the size and character of each settlement in order to maintain their vitality. This could be achieved by a mechanism which related consideration of new development proposals to a proportion of existing dwelling numbers within the settlement over a given time period subject to caveats about protection of the character of the settlement.

Definitions:

Limited Development:

In clause 2 of the policy above, in terms of housing, “limited development” means individual schemes of up to ten dwellings providing about a 10% increase in a settlement’s total dwelling number during the Local Plan period, limited to about 30% of this increase in any five year period.

Small Scale Development:

In clause 3 of the policy above, in terms of housing, “small scale development” means individual schemes of up to five dwellings providing about a 10% increase in a settlement’s total dwelling number during the Local Plan period, limited to about 30% of this increase in any five year period.

Primary Villages (showing dwelling numbers at the start of the plan period):

Bicknoller (122), Carhampton (317), Crowcombe (89), Kilve (110), Stogumber (164), Stogursey (388), West Quantoxhead (124) and Washford (304).

These are the larger villages with a shop and some built community facilities which are not significantly constrained by poor access from the County Highway Network.

Secondary Villages (showing dwelling numbers at the start of the plan period):

Holford (85), Dunster Marsh (168), Battleton (43), Brompton Ralph (23) and Brushford (179).

These are mainly smaller villages without a shop, but with some built community facilities, and also some with a shop but which are constrained by poor access from the County Highway Network.

Built up area:

An amalgam of buildings and built structures that collectively form a distinct developed form with a relatively continuous outer boundary / limit. The extent of the

built up area excludes parkland, parks, public gardens, formal and informal public open space, playing fields (including those associated with sports and educational institutions) and groups of farm and agriculture-related buildings where they are not wholly surrounded by other built development.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 108, 112, 118, 119 and, 123

POLICY SC2: HOUSING PROVISION

The plan will deliver approximately 2,900 dwellings to provide for the area's housing needs during the period to 2032, of which a minimum of 1,450 will be provided on allocated key strategic sites at Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet and Williton.

Purpose

- o To set out the approximate quantity of dwellings to be provided at each of the major settlements and in the primary and secondary villages as a whole,
- o To provide an appropriate level of development to support the continuing role and function of the respective settlements including the larger villages which have an elementary service provision role.

Assumptions

- o That directing the majority of new development in approximate proportion to the relative level of services provided at the District's main service centres will maximise their sustainability in terms of the range and quality of facilities available for the community and minimising longer trips from the area to centres elsewhere should local facilities be lost.
- o The housing provision figure for the West Somerset LPA area includes a specific allowance of 450 dwellings which arises from the likely impact on the local housing market of the Hinkley Point C project. This requirement would not arise in the event the new nuclear power station was not constructed.

Justification

- o c.80% of completions are consistently provided at Minehead/ Alcombe Watchet and Williton. This level of provision (at approximately the annual rate now proposed on the basis of the SHMA's evidence) has proved remarkably successful in maintaining Minehead/Alcombe as the main service centre with a good range of service provision for a town of its scale, and Watchet and Williton as two successful secondary service centres.
- o Village services have fared less well, with closures of village shops and post offices a particular issue. The population of rural West Somerset is relatively small and is thinly scattered in small settlements and farms. It is therefore

appropriate to encourage limited development within villages subject to appropriate location and scale.

- o The NPPF requires that the Councils meet the full objectively assessed need for housing (OAHN). In the case of the West Somerset Local Planning Authority area, a significant proportion of the housing need arises from the likely impacts on the local housing market of the Hinkley Point C project. As such it is appropriate for this to be reflected accordingly when assessing the amount of new housing which should be delivered over the Plan Period.
- o In terms of distribution, it is anticipated that new housing within the Local Plan area will be delivered at an average annualised rate of 145 dwellings per year over the whole of the plan-period:
 - Of these the strategic sites will provide:
 - An annualised average of 38 dwellings per year at Minehead/Alcombe,
 - An annualised average of 15 dwellings per year at Watchet,
 - An annualised average of 21 dwellings per year at Williton,
 - In addition to the key strategic sites, provision will be made for:
 - An annualised average of 43 dwellings per year through other development at Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet and Williton, and;
 - An annualised average of 30 dwellings per year will be provided at the Primary and Secondary Villages.
 - It should be noted that housing delivery in the Local Plan area has consistently provided an average of about 120 completions annually over the last 40 years. Windfalls have formed a major part of these completions.
 - Due to the long period of construction of the proposed new nuclear power station at Hinkley Point and the variable rate of people employed on site during this, it is anticipated that the impact on the local housing market will take a while to create its own demand. In order to account for this in estimating an average future delivery-rate, a two-step approach has been adopted to reflect this, comprising:
 - For the first six years from 2012/13 to 2017/18, an average delivery rate of 122 dwellings per annum, and
 - For the remaining fourteen years from 2018/19 to 2031/32, an average delivery rate of 155 dwellings per annum.
 - The small scale of development proposals and opportunities within West Somerset's major communities, and their distance from the M5 corridor have combined to reduce the level of interest in the area by major house builders.

- The limited range of employment opportunities in West Somerset (and their generally low wage levels) has had the effect of reducing the demand for open market housing within its main communities where development is acceptable in principle. (However, the market for characterful houses of comparatively high value in more remote rural locations remains strong.)
- Much of the assessed need is for affordable housing, the delivery of which is only likely to be viable if provided through planning agreements or cross subsidy by market housing.

Definition:

Annualised average = average rate of development for each year derived from the relevant total amount divided by the plan period (20 years).

(NB: This should not be interpreted as an annual absolute, rationing development.)

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 47, 49, 68, 69, 71, 94, 111, 118, 119 and, 123.

POLICY SC3: APPROPRIATE MIX OF HOUSING TYPES AND TENURES

Residential and mixed development proposals should provide a mix of housing sizes, tenures and types to meet the demonstrated needs of the area's communities.

Purpose

- o To ensure that development proposals take account of the housing needs of different groups within West Somerset's communities, and in particular the elderly. Proposals must include a statement of how the nature and design of the development takes account of the needs of different groups within the community.
- o To encourage the provision of lifetime homes and a proportion of bungalows etc. this is particularly important in view of the demographic changes occurring in the District and particularly the imbalance in the proportion of old/young people.

Assumptions

- o That the increasing proportion of elderly people in the population is not reflected in the proportion of different types of dwelling within the area.
- o Many elderly people in the Local Plan area are over-housed in properties which, in some cases, no longer offer practical living accommodation for them.
- o The provision of a wider range of house types would offer people the opportunity to move to more appropriate accommodation whilst remaining in their local area.

Justification

- o The Strategic Housing Market Assessments (SHMA) include information about the demographic breakdown of the area's population. New housing to be provided in the area should most appropriately reflect the range of people who are likely to inhabit the various parts of the area. This should be assessed within the constraints of the available data.
- o The West Somerset SHMA Update 2013 provides an assessment of the future type (as determined by number of bedrooms) and tenure required to meet the future housing need. Development proposals would need to demonstrate their contribution to meeting these needs unless, more up-to-date, localised housing assessments can demonstrate otherwise.

**Projected net housing requirements for West Somerset 2011-2031,
without backlog**

Tenure	Sector	1 bed	2 bed	3 bed	4+ bed	Total No.	Total %
Affordable	Social Rent	588	74	593	-4	1,251	52.16
	Affordable Rent	111	14	112	-1	236	9.86
Intermediate	Shared Ownership	198	25	200	-1	421	17.57
Market	Private Rent	32	4	32	0	68	2.84
	Owner Occupier	198	25	200	-1	421	17.57
Total no.	All sectors	1,127	142	1,136	-8	2,398	100.00
Total %	All sectors	46.99	5.94	47.40	-0.33		100.00

Housing Vision; Strategic Housing Market Assessment: West Somerset Update – Final Report, November 2013

As part of the future housing requirements in the LPA area, it is calculated that there will be a specific need for 351 units (14.64%) of specialised housing for older households.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 6, 15, 33, 46, 47, 66, 68, 69, 112, 118 and, 122.

POLICY SC4: AFFORDABLE HOUSING

- 1. Where residential development is proposed, on-site provision should be made for affordable housing to meet the needs of those with a local connection to West Somerset who cannot afford to access the open housing market throughout the local planning authority area on all sites of 11 or more dwellings.**
- 2. Affordable housing will be provided from developments in the minimum ratio of 35 affordable units for every 65 open-market (pro-rata) based on the total number of dwellings to be provided in the development.**
- 3. The affordable housing element will be provided on the following basis:**
 - A. Proportionate, like-for-like basis in terms of housing size and type, with a minimum of 2 bedrooms, unless the latest housing needs survey evidence indicates otherwise**
 - B. Built to the minimum homes and communities agency standard sizes for type of dwelling or larger**
 - C. Built to a minimum of homes and communities agency design code 3 unless this has been superseded by higher code levels determined by the hca, successor agencies and/or the relevant central government department.**
- 4. Where residential development of between 6 and 10 dwellings is proposed at settlements identified in Policy SC1, but excluding Minehead/Alcombe and Watchet, financial contributions towards affordable housing will be sought in lieu of provision on-site. These will be calculated on the basis of the criteria in 2 and, 3 above.**
- 5. Where affordable housing for those in housing need with a local connection is justified at settlements not identified in Policy SC1, a proportion of market housing may be appropriate in order to enable the development to take place. In such cases the open market element will be restricted to the minimum required. The minimum proportion of affordable housing to market housing should be 35% : 65%.**

Purpose

- o The policy will help to secure a significant percentage of affordable houses (with a target of 35%) to be provided as part of any development of over 10 dwellings depending on its location as set out in the policy. In Williton and other settlements identified in Policy SC1 except for Minehead/Alcombe and Watchet, these fall within the definition of 'designated Rural Areas' and**

- o commuted financial contributions towards affordable housing can sought on developments of between 6 and 10 dwellings through Section 106/Planning Obligations agreements for provision off-site.
- o This policy will also provide for affordable housing in rural communities.

Assumptions

- o The provision of additional affordable housing as part of the costs of development is one means of improving access to a decent home in a suitable location for those on the locally prevalent low incomes.
- o In order to secure the benefit of affordable housing for the community it must be secured to meet such needs in the long term by means of appropriate legal agreements.

Justification

- o West Somerset District has one of the highest disparities between average earnings and average house price in the Country.
- o West Somerset is very attractive, and is a highly desirable area within which to relocate, particularly for those seeking a lifestyle change and/or retiring early from even higher value housing markets such as the south east of England and London. This flow of capital rich in-migrants, together with the high incidence of holiday cottage / second home purchases in the area has raised property values to a level which many local people cannot afford.
- o A lack of sufficient social housing for rent to meet local needs means that many of those on lower incomes cannot afford to remain in West Somerset, or have to live in other people's households, causing overcrowding and loss of privacy to the detriment of all concerned.
- o It is essential that workers in a wide range of occupations are able to live and work locally, many jobs here are in the lower end of the earnings range. The removal of such workers from the local labour market will impact adversely on the local economy (particularly retail and tourism) and also on the provision of essential services such as social care.
- o Provision will normally be made on-site for developments of 11 or more dwellings. Exceptionally, on sites of 6 – 10 dwellings at identified settlements (in Policy SC1) that are in a designated Rural Area as set out in Statutory Instrument S.I.1997: No.621 or, that are in situations where an appropriate justification is demonstrated, off-site provision may be accepted.
- o The need for affordable housing in a particular settlement, including the preferred type and tenure, will be informed by an up to date housing needs survey.

- o Affordable housing will be considered on sites in and around settlements where there is, and is likely to continue to be a clear ongoing housing need for that type of housing in the settlement. There should be a clear employment, social and/or long-term family linkage between potential occupants and the settlement. There should be good access to basic essential facilities within the settlement or via access to good public transport connection nearby to neighbouring larger settlements.

Definitions:

Affordable Housing:

Term used for any form of housing, rented or ownership, which is delivered for those people who are unable to access housing within the market, usually but not exclusively for financial reasons. This would include the new affordable rent model (80% of market rent) championed by central government as well as traditional social rent, shared equity and low cost home ownership models.

Exceptions site:

Where there is a demonstrable need for affordable housing for people with a local connection to the parish in question at a settlement entirely within the open countryside, exceptionally, an appropriate amount of affordable housing may be permitted together with the minimum amount of market housing necessary to enable the development to come forward.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 10, 15, 18, 24, 35, 47, 58, 59, 60, 65, 67, 68, 69, 112, 117, 118, 120, 122 and,123.

POLICY SC5: SELF CONTAINMENT OF SETTLEMENTS

Development which improves the balance of land uses within a settlement in terms of minimising overall transport use will be encouraged.

Purpose

- o To seek to bring about a better balance in the provision of employment, services, housing and transport infrastructure so as to minimise transport demand insofar as is practical in West Somerset.

Assumptions

- o The highly dispersed settlement pattern and thinly spread population within most of the Local Plan area mean that the private car is the only realistic form of transport for making the journeys necessary for everyday life for much of West Somerset's population.
- o If enough uses can be located in the main service settlements, close to the (limited number of) effective public transport routes which do exist, ie: the A39 between Minehead and Bridgwater, and the A358 between Williton and Taunton, then what potential there is for the public having opportunities to use public transport is maximised. The potential for car borne journeys to be multi-purpose is also increased.
- o Employment location is a particularly powerful factor in this policy field. Additional employment uses, particularly of higher status will reduce the amount of commuting from West Somerset to the M5 corridor.
- o It is accepted that some journeys to access services and employment will be to larger centres such as Bristol, Exeter or Taunton. The impending new nuclear project at Hinkley Point is also likely to increase the amount of commuting from other parts of West Somerset and beyond.

Justification

- o Whilst it is recognised that planning for the car is the reality in West Somerset, national policy, and in particular the objectives of sustainable development require that a better mix of transport modes is encouraged. Effective planning policies can help to ensure that patterns of new development provision aim to minimise transport demand and maximise the attractiveness of walking and cycling as modes of transport in places such as Minehead in particular. The provision of the best range of services and facilities which can be achieved will help to increase the self-containment of the larger settlements, and this again applies particularly to Minehead.

Definition:

Settlement:

In the context of these policies, 'settlement' means Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet, Williton and the Primary and Secondary Villages as identified in Policy SC1.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 10, 15, 47, 68, 108, 112, 118, 119 and, 122.

POLICY SC6: SAFEGUARDING OF VILLAGE FACILITIES.

Development resulting in the loss of community facilities such as public houses and shops where these are the last such facilities in, or serving a settlement, will be resisted unless it can be demonstrated that the business is not and cannot be made viable, and that all reasonable efforts have been made to sell, rent and /or lease the business (at a competitive price for comparable uses) for a minimum of twelve months and has generated no interest.

Purpose

- o Whilst appropriate additions to the mix of uses can serve to enhance self-containment, the loss of local facilities can have an adverse impact. The policy seeks to ensure that all avenues have been explored and exhausted before valuable economic local facilities such as a shop or public house are lost.

Assumptions

- o The highly dispersed settlement pattern and thinly spread population within most of the Local Plan area mean that the private car is the only realistic form of transport for making the journeys necessary for everyday life for much of West Somerset's population.
- o If enough uses can be located in the main service settlements, close to the (limited number of) effective public transport routes which do exist, ie: the A39 between Minehead and Bridgwater, and the A358 between Williton and Taunton, then what potential there is for the public having opportunities to use public transport is maximised. The potential for car borne journeys to be multi-purpose is also increased.
- o The retention of local facilities particularly in the villages can help to minimise transport demand as well as maintaining community life.
- o Employment location is a particularly powerful factor in this policy field. Additional employment uses, particularly of higher status will reduce the amount of commuting from West Somerset to the M5 corridor.
- o It is accepted that some journeys to access services and employment will be to larger centres such as Bristol, Exeter or Taunton. The impending new nuclear project at Hinkley Point is also likely to increase the amount of commuting from other parts of West Somerset and beyond.

Justification

- o Whilst it is recognised that planning for the car is the reality in West Somerset, national policy, and in particular the objectives of sustainable development require that a better mix of transport modes is encouraged. Effective planning policies can help to ensure that patterns of new development provision aim to minimise transport demand and maximise the attractiveness of walking and cycling as modes of transport in places such as Minehead in particular. The provision of the best range of services and facilities which can be achieved will help to increase the self-containment of the larger settlements, and this again applies particularly to Minehead.
- o Recognition of the identification of local economic facilities as Assets of Community Value under the provisions of the Localism Act.

Definition:

Settlement:

In the context of these policies, 'settlement' means Minehead/ Alcombe, Watchet, Williton and the Primary and Secondary Villages as identified in Policy SC1.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 10, 15, 47, 68, 108, 112, 118, 120 and 122.

POLICY MD1: MINEHEAD/ALCOMBE DEVELOPMENT

Development proposals at Minehead/Alcombe, must:

- support and strengthen the settlement's role as the main service and employment centre in West Somerset, particularly in terms of the diversity and quality of its historic and natural environment, services and facilities, and;
- sustain and enhance the historic environment of the urban area;
- maintain and enhance its attractiveness as a tourist destination, and;

Where appropriate development proposals must also:

- contribute towards resolving the flood risk issues which affect the settlement including improving the sea defences protecting the eastern end of the town,
- give appropriate treatment to the town's surroundings in the context of national designations including the Exmoor National Park.

Purpose

- o To protect and enhance Minehead & Alcombe's key role in the local economy and also in the provision of community services for the wider area.
- o To address the shortcomings in the town's coastal flood defences at the eastern end of the town.
- o To fulfil these aims whilst protecting the town's high quality landscape setting.

Assumptions

- o That maintaining and strengthening the range of service, recreation, education and employment facilities in Minehead & Alcombe will improve the quality of life for the town's inhabitants (and those of its hinterland) and
- o It will also reduce the number of journeys to other main centres to access services not available in the town.

Justification

- o Minehead/Alcombe is the major centre of population in the District (11,981), having approximately a third of the total population (including the Exmoor National Park area). It performs a critical role in the servicing of a large and thinly populated rural hinterland extending well outside the Local Plan area that is relatively remote from larger settlements such as Barnstaple, Bridgwater, Taunton and, Tiverton. The continuing economic health of the town is essential not only to the quality of life of residents and visitors, but also to the maintenance of the relatively high level of self-containment which the area enjoys. Development proposals which could damage its importance by

reducing the range and level of service facilities available should therefore be resisted, whilst it would be beneficial to encourage proposals which support the services which already exist, or add to them at an appropriate level.

- o Minehead/Alcombe provides a wide range of facilities for a large and relatively inaccessible area. Facilities include the community hospital, community college (sixth form), middle school, police, fire and ambulance stations, town centre and foodstores.
- o It is also an important tourism destination with hotels / guest houses, seafront, holiday camp, steam railway and easy access to Exmoor.
- o Minehead is the focus of public transport services linking to the M5 at both Taunton and Bridgwater
- o Environmental considerations include a substantial area in the south east of the settlement which is at high risk of coastal flooding for which sea defences exist, and the high quality landscape which surrounds the town to the north, west and south.
- o A surface water management plan has been prepared for Minehead.
- o Minehead lies relatively close to the designated area of the Exmoor National Park which lies some distance beyond the southern and western fringes of the town. Development proposals particularly on these edges of the town should be designed in such a way as to respond sympathetically to the National Park's historic and traditional landscape.
- o The design of lighting schemes for development at Minehead should seek to minimise the amount of light pollution created in order to minimise any adverse impact on the Exmoor National Park Dark Sky Reserve.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 72, 82, 89, 108, 109, 110, 112, 118, 120, 121, 122 and, 126.

POLICY MD2:

KEY STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENT ALLOCATION AT MINEHEAD/ALCOMBE

Within the area identified on the policies map south of the A39, Hopcott Road, Minehead/Alcombe a mixed development will be delivered subject to an indicative masterplan incorporating:

- approximately 750 dwellings,
- a distributor road through the site linking the development to the A39 at two points, one close to each end of the site,
- provide space for the future linkage of the distributor road to the LT1 site to the west, and;
- a minimum of 3 hectares of appropriate and compatible, non-residential uses.
- measures to prevent harm to the significance of historic assets of the late 19th/early 20th century villas on Hopcott Road/Periton Road; Lower Hopcott; Periton & Periton Cottages; grade II listed buildings and Higher Hopcott, and;
- which provides an appropriate design response to the site's proximity to the Exmoor National Park

The development must be facilitated by the appropriate integrated provision of transport, community and flood risk management infrastructure.

Purpose

- o To provide for an appropriate additional amount of housing, commercial and community land uses in the most sustainable location available at Minehead.

Assumptions

- o That the provision of a significant amount of housing (and supporting mixed use) development at Minehead / Alcombe will serve to maintain and strengthen Minehead's role and function as a main service centre for the wider area and minimise the need to travel out of the local area to access facilities in more distant centres.
- o The development of the site will be subject to an overall master-plan including phasing where appropriate.
- o The provision of strategic development at this location will:
- o Help to minimise the risk from flooding
- o Minimise the walking time from the new development into the town centre and to other local facilities.

Justification

The strategy requires that the largest part of the strategic housing provision in the plan should be provided at Minehead/Alcombe:

- o So that additional transport demand is minimised and access to non-private car transport modes is maximised (notwithstanding the recognised limitations of public transport in the area), it is essential to locate the largest part of it where the best range of services are available. Also Minehead is the main focus for public transport services in West Somerset.
- o The necessity of accessing the site properly, addressing constraints and providing a comprehensively planned approach to open space, movement routes and biodiversity means that a masterplan will be required to guide the implementation of development on the site. The Masterplan must also provide for future linkage of the distributor road through the longer term development site LT1 to a third junction with the A39.
- o So that flood risk within the area is appropriately managed, and especially that the potential for flood risk in the area to the north east of Seaward Way is addressed as part of any development.
- o So that impact on the landscape is managed appropriately. The land identified by this policy is unconstrained by specific flooding or landscape designations. Detailed design of schemes can address this the biodiversity issue identified in the Habitat Regulations Assessment. However, there are potentially impacts on the Barbastelle bat feature of the outside of designated boundary the Exmoor and Quantocks Oak Woodlands SAC which nonetheless ecologically support its conservation objectives.
- o So that any impacts on the Barbastelle bat feature of the Exmoor and Quantocks Oak Woodlands SAC can be offset within the Areas of Search (A4, A5 and A6) see Plan 1 attached. Biodiversity offsetting is likely to be required as a result of the assessment under the Habitats Regulations 2010 at a project level for these sites.
- o So that impact upon the natural and historic heritage is managed in an appropriate way,
- o To avoid the provision of large amounts of new residential development in less well serviced parts of the District.
- o Commits West Somerset Council to the preparation of an indicative masterplan in order to help to guide the emerging development proposals for the site so that the Plan's strategy will not be prejudiced.

- o Minehead lies relatively close to the designated area of the Exmoor National Park which lies some distance beyond the southern and western fringes of the town. Development proposals particularly on these edges of the town should be designed in such a way as to respond sympathetically to the National Park's historic and traditional landscape.
- o The design of lighting schemes for development at Minehead should seek to minimise the amount of light pollution created in order to minimise any adverse impact on the Exmoor National Park Dark Sky Reserve.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 71, 72, 108, 118, 119, 122, 124 and, 126.

POLICY WA1: WATCHET DEVELOPMENT

Development proposals at Watchet, must:

- **support and strengthen the settlement's role as a local service and employment centre for the north eastern part of West Somerset district, particularly in terms of the range and quality of its services and facilities, and**
- **sustain and enhance the attractiveness of the historic character and heritage assets as a tourist destination, including the operation of the marina.**

Where appropriate, development proposals must also:

- **contribute towards resolving the flood risk issues which affect the settlement,**
- **allow for potential realignment of the West Somerset railway which may be necessitated by coastal erosion,**
- **improve linkages between the town centre and the parts of the town to the south of the railway,**
- **provide additional allotments for the town, and;**
- **complement the provision of employment opportunities, services and facilities in neighbouring Williton.**

Purpose

- o To protect and enhance Watchet's important service and employment role in the local economy and also in the provision of community services for the wider area in conjunction with the neighbouring settlement of Williton.
- o To address the severance of the town centre from the bulk of the town's residential property which lies to the south east of the railway. There is currently a single road crossing, a bridge with no footways, as well as a pedestrian level crossing and a traditional railway footbridge. Options for improvement are limited but should be explored in conjunction with the additional traffic, both vehicular and pedestrian, which would arise from further development south of the railway line.
- o Watchet is a tourist centre in its own right; this forms an important part of the local economy. The encouragement of tourism development is of benefit to the town and the surrounding area.
- o Active coastal erosion affects the coastline around the town, including the section at Helwell Bay between Watchet and Doniford, where the West Somerset Railway runs close to the edge of the sea cliff. As this cliff erodes,

it will be necessary to re-align the railway if this key piece of tourism infrastructure is to remain intact.

Assumptions

- o That maintaining and strengthening the range of service, recreation, education and employment facilities in Watchet will improve the quality of life for the town's inhabitants (and those of its hinterland) and
- o It will also reduce the number of journeys to other main centres to access services not available in the town.

Justification

- o Watchet is the second largest centre of population in the District (population 3,785). It has a role along with the neighbouring settlement of Williton, of being an important secondary service centre to Minehead/Alcombe, helping to serve the north eastern part of the District in particular.
- o Development proposals which could damage its importance by reducing the range and level of service facilities available should therefore be resisted, whilst it would be beneficial to encourage proposals which support the services which already exist, or add to them at an appropriate level.
- o The paper mill is the most significant employers within the District, its retention is highly desirable. Watchet is also a significant tourism destination with hotels/guest houses, esplanade, marina, steam railway and coast.
- o Since the railway was built in the 1860s the town has expanded significantly to the south east, such that the majority of the town's population lives on the other side of the railway from the town centre. Links across the railway are limited to a single road bridge with no footways, a traditional railway footbridge and a pedestrian level crossing. In particular, better provision for those using pushchairs, wheelchairs or mobility scooters in the general vicinity of the road bridge would be of considerable benefit for the local population.
- o Environmental considerations include an area in the valley bottom in the vicinity of the paper mill which is at high risk of flooding.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 34, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 74, 83, 108, 112, 114, 118, 120, 122, 124 and, 126.

POLICY WA2:

STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENT ALLOCATION AT PARSONAGE FARM, WATCHET

Within the area identified on the policies map at Parsonage Farm, Watchet, a mixed development will be delivered including subject to an indicative masterplan incorporating:

- approximately 290 dwellings,
- approximately 3 hectares of appropriate and compatible, non-residential uses at the farm building complex, and;
- measures to prevent harm to the significance of historic assets at parsonage farm, grade ii listed buildings and their settings, and;
- provide additional allotments

The development must be facilitated by the appropriate integrated provision of transport, community and flood risk management infrastructure to include walking and cycling links connecting the new development with the town centre.

Purpose

- o To provide for an appropriate additional amount of housing, commercial and community land uses in the most sustainable location available at Watchet in order to support and enhance the services and role of the town.

Assumptions

- o That a significant allocation of new development to the town will increase activity in the local economy serving to improve the viability of local services to the benefit of both the residents of Watchet and the wider community.
- o The development of the site will be subject to an overall master-plan including phasing where appropriate.
- o The master-plan will also take account of the significance of the 'Listed' historic assets at Parsonage Farm and their settings as described in the, Parsonage Farm Heritage Assessment.

Justification

- o As set out above, the plan proposes to provide for 2,900 dwellings over the plan period on the basis of the evidence. In order to meet this level of provision in the most sustainable way it is desirable to deliver the majority of these dwellings at the three main settlements of Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet and Williton including some 290 dwellings at Watchet.
- o Such a distribution will help to ensure that:

- Watchet's important service provision role for the north eastern part of the District will be strengthened.
 - Flood risk within the area is not made worse. There are areas at high risk of flooding at Watchet, principally within the old town and the valley running inland including much of the paper mill site.
 - Impact on the landscape is managed appropriately. The land identified by this policy is unconstrained by flooding, landscape or nature conservation designations. It will be necessary to ensure that development proposed under this policy does not become visible from the south above the ridge forming the landscape boundary between Watchet and Williton.
 - The provision of pedestrian and cycleway links to the town centre from the new development is essential in order to avoid severance.
 - Impact upon the natural and historic heritage is managed in an appropriate way taking account of the significance of the 'Listed' historic assets at Parsonage Farm and their settings as described in the, Parsonage Farm Heritage Assessment.
- o This development is proposed along with that in Williton and Minehead/ Alcombe to avoid the provision of large amounts of residential development in less well serviced parts of the District.
 - o West Somerset Council will lead the preparation of an indicative masterplan in order to help to guide the emerging development proposals for the site so that the Plan's strategy will not be prejudiced.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 71, 72, 108, 118, 119, 122, 124 and, 126

POLICY WI1: WILLITON DEVELOPMENT

Development proposals at Williton must:

- **Support and strengthen the settlement's role as a local service, administrative and employment centre for the north eastern part of West Somerset district, particularly in terms of the range and quality of its services and facilities, and;**
- **Contribute to the improvement of traffic and transport management within the village, and;**
- **Complement the provision of employment opportunities, services and facilities in neighbouring Watchet**

Where appropriate, development must contribute towards resolving the flood risk issues which affect the settlement.

Purpose

- o To protect and enhance Williton's important service and employment role in the local economy and also in the provision of community services for the wider area in conjunction with the neighbouring settlement of Watchet.
- o To address the traffic management issues which affect the village due to a combination of narrow streets with narrow or absent footways and the fact that the two busiest roads in the District – the A358 and the A39 – meet in the centre of the village causing significant levels of congestion at peak times. There is also considerable conflict with local traffic movements connected with local shops and services which exacerbate the problems.
- o Williton lies at the confluence of the Doniford Stream and the Monksilver Stream, the latter passes close to the centre of the village in a narrow and constrained channel. There is a history of flooding relating to both streams, and also to the area to the west of the village which used to be managed as water meadows and which retains a small watercourse linking the Monksilver Stream upstream of the village, with the Doniford Stream downstream of the main confluence. Any management changes proposed to these watercourses in association with Strategic development at Williton should be considered in the context of the legal requirements of the Water Framework Directive in order to protect their 'Good Ecological Status'.
- o Williton is the main administrative centre for the District, having the District Council offices. There is also a community hospital, fire station, middle school library and police station. This service role is of benefit to the wider area and the District as a whole. It is essential that this level of provision should be retained or improved.

Assumptions

- o That maintaining and strengthening the range of service, recreation, education and employment facilities in Williton will improve the quality of life for the village's inhabitants (and those of its hinterland) and
- o It will also reduce the number of journeys to other main centres to access services not available in the village.

Justification

- o Williton is the third largest centre of population in the District (population 2,697). It has a role along with the neighbouring settlement of Watchet, of being an important secondary service centre to Minehead/Alcombe, helping to serve the north eastern part of the District in particular.
- o Development proposals which could damage its importance by reducing the range and level of service facilities available should therefore be resisted, whilst it would be beneficial to encourage proposals which support the services which already exist, or add to them at an appropriate level.
- o Traffic congestion is a severe problem at peak times, particularly in the main holiday season. Williton, in common with other settlements on the A39 corridor for which by-pass schemes were planned in the past but which failed to be prioritised for funding and have since been cancelled.
- o Environmental considerations include significant areas of the village which are at high risk of flooding.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 84, 91, 108, 112, 118, 120, 122, 124, 125 and, 126.

POLICY WI2:

KEY STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENT ALLOCATIONS AT WILLITON

Within the areas identified on the policies map to the west and north of Williton, mixed development will be delivered subject to an indicative masterplan incorporating:

- **approximately 406 dwellings, and;**
- **approximately 3 hectares of appropriate and compatible, non-residential uses.**
- **enhancement of the designated heritage asset Battlegore Barrow Cemetery and its setting should take place. The site should be enhanced to ensure its use as a communal asset and contribute positively to the community. This should be achieved through landscaping, public access, appropriate use of the site and the implementation of a management plan agreed with Historic England.**

The development must be facilitated by the appropriate integrated provision of transport, community and flood risk management infrastructure to include walking and cycling links connecting the new development with the village centre.

Purpose

- o To provide for an appropriate additional amount of housing, commercial and community land uses in the most sustainable location available at Williton in order to support and enhance the services and role of the village.

Assumptions

- o That a significant allocation of new development to the town will increase activity in the local economy serving to improve the viability of local services to the benefit of both the residents of Williton and the wider community.
- o The development of the site will be subject to an overall master-plan including phasing where appropriate.

Justification

- o As set out above, the plan proposes to provide for 2,900 dwellings over the plan period on the basis of the evidence. In order to meet this level of provision in the most sustainable way it is desirable to deliver the majority of these dwellings at the three main settlements of Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet and Williton including some 406 dwellings on sites at Williton.
- o Such a distribution will help to ensure that:
 - Williton's important service provision role for the north eastern part of the District will be strengthened.

- Flood risk within the area is not made worse. There are areas at high risk of flooding at Williton, both within and around the village in association with the Monksilver Stream and its related watercourses and the Doniford Stream which it joins close to the railway station.
 - Impact on the landscape is managed appropriately. The land identified by this policy is unconstrained by landscape or nature conservation designations, however it is adjacent to land affected by flooding, and an appropriate flood risk management strategy will have to be implemented as part of the proposed development.
- o development is proposed to the west and north of the village because:
- The village's commercial and service centre is well related to the proposed strategic sites. Development in these locations will help to ensure that the maximum number of local trips are made on foot or by bicycle.
 - It will also increase the likelihood that the new residents will use the local shops and facilities, helping to sustain the vitality of the village centre.
 - Other potential strategic development locations to the east of the village are more difficult to access such that inhabitants would be more likely to use their cars to access the centre. Once in their cars, residents are more likely to drive further to the wider range of facilities available in the next nearest service centres of Minehead, Taunton or Bridgwater, giving rise to higher carbon dioxide emissions and reducing the amount of business in the village shops. Other adverse factors affecting this area are that achieving an appropriate vehicular access for this location is likely to prove difficult, and that the area falls within the proposed Bat Consultation Zone (see Policy NH8 and, for more detail, the Preferred Strategy Habitat Regulations Assessment).
- o The provision of pedestrian and cycleway links to the village centre from the new development is essential in order to avoid severance.
- o The Battlegore barrow cemetery lies close to the area identified for development, it will be essential to protect and enhance its heritage value in designing and implementing the development.
- o This development is proposed along with that in Watchet and Minehead/ Alcombe to avoid the provision of large amounts of residential development in less well serviced parts of the District.
- o West Somerset Council will lead the preparation of an indicative masterplan in order to help to guide the emerging development proposals for the sites so that the Plan's strategy will not be prejudiced.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 71, 108, 118, 120, 122, 124 and, 126.

POLICY LT1: POST 2026 KEY STRATEGIC DEVELOPMENT SITES

Within the two areas identified for longer term strategic development on the Policies Map:

- to the south of Periton Road, Minehead for which access would be via a distributor road through the site linking the distributor road for the MD2 site with the site's A39 frontage and;
- to the west of Watchet at Cleeve Hill, where development must contribute to enhancing the unique historic environment of the town including mitigating the erosion of Daw's Castle and encouraging visitors to the monument through funding excavations and improvement of site management, and also to providing a new alignment for the B3191 to address the impact of coastal erosion,
- proposals for the Watchet site must sustain and, where appropriate, enhance the historic assets of Daw's Castle and the adjacent lime kilns and their settings.
- development of both of these sites would be guided by the provision of indicative masterplans.
- in respect of the Minehead long term site, the masterplan should provide for an appropriate design response to the site's proximity to the Exmoor National Park.
- the masterplan for the Watchet long term site should include the use of soft landscaping, green spaces and sympathetic design in terms of appearance to mitigate harm.

Provision is made for development in the latter part of the plan period post 2026.

Purpose

- o In order to provide for the strategic development needs of the area in the later part of the plan period, it is essential to reserve some strategic development sites for development at that stage.

Assumptions

- o There will remain a need for strategic development sites in the post-2026 part of the Local Plan period, without taking steps to reserve land for this purpose such land may not be available when it is needed.
- o The development of the sites will be subject to an overall master-plan including phasing where appropriate.

Justifications

- o These two sites are held in reserve as a contingency and could potentially be released early if monitoring demonstrates a significant, ongoing shortfall in the

rate of development of the Key Strategy Sites for Minehead and Watchet, or if those sites deliver less housing than anticipated in the Plan. The Watchet LT1 site could also be brought forward if the need to realign the B3191 becomes imperative due to coastal erosion.

- o Land between Hopcott and Periton, south of the A39 Periton Road at Minehead is the next most sustainable strategic development option for Minehead after the development of the land allocated by Policy MD2. It would be proposed for development subject to similar conditions as Policy MD2 regarding the treatment of biodiversity including the barbastelle bats, and the landscape setting of the site.
- o Minehead lies relatively close to the designated area of the Exmoor National Park which lies some distance beyond the southern and western fringes of the town. Development proposals particularly on these edges of the town should be designed in such a way as to respond sympathetically to the National Park's historic and traditional landscape.
- o The design of lighting schemes for development at Minehead should seek to minimise the amount of light pollution created in order to minimise any adverse impact on the Exmoor National Park Dark Sky Reserve.
- o The site at Cleeve Hill, Watchet is relatively close to the town centre, and also offers the potential to re-align the B3191 where coastal erosion is threatening to destroy the current alignment of the road.
- o Options for rescue archaeology excavations in advance of further coastal erosion of Daws Castle will be sought through Section 106 Agreements with developers.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 72, 108, 112, 118, 120, 122, 124 and, 126.

POLICY SV1: DEVELOPMENT AT PRIMARY AND SECONDARY VILLAGES

Development at primary and secondary villages should:

- **be designed to form an integral, harmonious addition to the settlement's existing character**
- **help to maintain or enhance their existing level of service provision, and also help to create balanced communities at a level appropriate to their role and function.**

Purpose

- o The policy is proposed in order to enhance and sustain the economic and social vitality of the larger rural villages
- o It will provide a spatial strategy for the villages in the A39 and A358 corridors and also for the Brendon Hills and Exmoor fringe communities.

Assumptions

- o That a modest amount of new development can help to maintain the vitality of the larger villages, particularly if economic as well as residential development is provided, for example in the form of work-live units.

Justification

- o There are a number of factors which justify a policy seeking to bring new residential and employment development to villages in West Somerset:
- o There is a strong demand for second homes and holiday cottages which increases property prices
- o In-migration of early retirees and families from areas such as the west midlands and south east of England where property values are higher also increases property values
- o The predominantly low wage economy in the area, which reduces the ability of local people to afford access to the West Somerset housing market.
- o The Taylor Report concluded that development in village communities was an appropriate way of addressing the need to retain vital communities in rural areas, without which rural populations will become increasingly reliant on urban areas for their services.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 15, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 108, 112, 118, 119, 122, 124 and, 126.

POLICY OC1: OPEN COUNTRYSIDE DEVELOPMENT

The open countryside includes all land outside of existing settlements, where development is not generally appropriate. In exceptional circumstances development may be permitted where this is beneficial for the community and local economy.

- Development in the open countryside (land not adjacent or in close proximity to the major settlements, primary and secondary villages) will only be permitted where it can be demonstrated that:
- such a location is essential for a rural worker engaged in e.g: agricultural, forestry, horticulture, equestrian or hunting employment, or;
- it is provided through the conversion of existing, traditionally constructed buildings in association with employment or tourism purposes as part of a work/live development, or;
- it is new-build to benefit existing employment activity already established in the area that could not be easily accommodated within or adjoining a nearby settlement identified in Policy SC1, or;
- it meets an ongoing identified local need for affordable housing in the nearby settlement which cannot be met within or closer to the settlement, or;
- it is an affordable housing exceptions scheme adjacent to, or in close proximity to, a settlement in the open countryside permitted in accordance with Policy SC4(5).

Applications for dwellings under this policy that would not be located in a settlement identified in Policy SC1 or any other settlement, would be considered subject to a functional and economic test. Where permission is granted consideration would be given to this being initially made on a temporary basis.

Purpose

- o To protect the open countryside from damaging development whilst exceptionally allowing development which is beneficial to the health of the community and / or the local economy to take place.

Assumptions

- o That it is generally desirable to protect the open countryside from development.
- o That there are circumstances in which it is appropriate to allow a strictly limited amount of development in the open countryside for land management, social or economic reasons.

Justification

- o New-build development for employment generating activities already established in the local area will be considered where the type of activity in its existing location is incompatible with existing neighbouring uses. The re-location of any relevant employment generating activity would also need to take account of any relevant parts of Policy EC5 and Policy EC9.
- o Essential dwellings for rural workers may be permitted subject to a rigorous assessment of the necessity for the development in the location proposed, and in particular, why an existing dwelling in the local area cannot suffice. The justification for such dwellings must include setting out the functional need for a dwelling in that location and economic evidence to demonstrate the potential viability of the scheme. These will include the following criteria;

Functional

- there is an existing and established need for the activity in the area,
- the need requires the presence of a full-time worker employed in the activity on-site to provide availability to meet local emergencies associated with it, on a 24/7 basis,
- the need could not be met effectively through use of existing off-site accommodation nearby, and,
- other planning requirements, such as siting and access, can be satisfied.

Economic

- the activity can demonstrate that it has been generating an regular on-going need for at least three years, and,
- the proposed accommodation should be commensurate with the established functional need for accommodation in that location.

Because it will not be clear whether an enterprise will prove to be viable in advance, initial permissions under this policy may be granted on a temporary basis.

- o The re-use and conversion of existing traditional buildings in the open countryside for alternative uses can, if sensitively implemented in order to maximise the retention of the traditional character of the buildings, make a significant contribution to protecting the character and heritage of the rural landscape.
- o Reasons for preventing development in the open countryside are that:

dispersed development disproportionately increases transport demand which can usually only be fulfilled by use of the private car.

- It is significantly more expensive per capita to deliver services to a dispersed rural population than for population concentrated in larger settlements.

- Development in the open countryside changes its character frequently bringing an undesirable modern urban element into it with adverse heritage impact.
 - The attractiveness of the area to tourists, who form an essential part of the local economy, depends to a great extent on the beauty and historic character of the landscape and rural settlements.
 - There is a high suppressed demand for houses in rural settings reflected in the higher prices which houses in such locations command on the open market, without planning policy restraint there would be a large number of new dwellings constructed in a scattered pattern across the District. This would be harmful in its impact for the reasons set out above.
- o Reasons for allowing development in the open countryside are that:
- Certain types of agricultural, forestry, equine, horticultural or hunting enterprise need close supervision which can only be provided by having someone living on or near to the site. In exceptional cases, this need cannot be met through the use of existing housing stock in the local area, subject to a detailed and compelling justification, there may be an economic case for allowing a new dwelling.
 - Where traditional buildings are being conserved through conversion for a business use including tourism accommodation or a live / work development, a new residential dwelling may be permitted as part of the conversion scheme in order to assist with the provision of jobs in rural areas.
 - Affordable housing where there is a demonstrated local need can be allowed in order to maintain the balance and health of the local community.
 - All of these subject to the need to minimise additional transport demand. This is particularly important in relation to tourism or business activities.
- o See also transport Policy TR2.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 15, 37, 47, 68, 70, 71, 108, 112, 118, 119, 122, 124 and, 126.

ECONOMY

POLICY EC1: WIDENING AND STRENGTHENING THE LOCAL ECONOMY

Proposals which will make the West Somerset economy stronger and more diverse and that are likely to increase the proportion of higher paid jobs locally will be supported.

New development, redevelopment and, conversion proposals for all types of employment generating activities will be encouraged.

Where possible, such proposals should make use of existing employment sites, or of sites with similar and compatible uses where the development proposed would not have an adverse impact on the amenity of existing neighbouring uses.

Purpose

- o To encourage a widening of the employment base within the area.
- o This includes taking advantage of the new economic activity brought by the Hinkley Point C proposals, which potentially offers a significant supply of relatively well paid and secure employment for the District's population.
- o To provide an appropriate supply of employment land.

Assumptions

That having a more diverse economy including more, higher paid employment will attract more people of working age to remain in West Somerset, or will encourage them to move here to work.

- o This in turn will improve the ratio of average earnings to average house price in the area.

Justification

- o One of the key weaknesses of the West Somerset economy is the predominantly low waged economy based on the tourism business, agriculture and social care. Bringing a wider range of work, and more, higher paid jobs to the area would increase the prosperity of the area and improve its facilities to the benefit of the population as a whole.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 36, 37, 50, 53, 108, 118, 119, 124 and, 126.

POLICY EC2: MAJOR EMPLOYMENT SITE

The employment site at Mart Road, is identified on the Policies Map. Within this site there will be a general presumption in favour of uses in the B1, B2 and B8 use classes.

Employment and service based land uses falling outside these use classes will be permitted where these can be demonstrated to make a positive contribution to the overall vitality and viability of the local economy.

Purpose

- o Providing for the expansion of existing businesses.
- o Providing for businesses requiring specific and/or bespoke premises.
- o Maintaining a key element in the local employment base.

Assumptions

- o Employment development should be accommodated on existing allocated employment land unless there is a sound reason why it should be located elsewhere.
- o It is beneficial to the local economy (and therefore the community) to have a secure supply of land for economic activity / employment use.

Justification

- o Employment land is allocated so as to be conveniently located for access by a range of employees and other visitors to the businesses situated there.
- o It can be more attractive to develop a business on a new unallocated site elsewhere, however this can have the effect of undermining the success of existing business areas, which can harm the local economy. In identifying locations for future employment development, consideration will be taken of the existing uses adjoining the site and/or are proposed to be approved or allocated nearby in order to avoid incompatible activities being located next to each other.
- o Priority will be given to those sites and land identified as being available and suitable for employment uses identified through the Employment Land Review and, they are consistent with other policies within the Local Plan and, they meet the relevant requirements of the NPPF.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 37, 50, 70, 108, 124 and, 126.

POLICY EC3: GREENFIELD EMPLOYMENT GENERATING DEVELOPMENT

Development proposals requiring a greenfield location will be directed to existing identified and/or allocated sites for those type of uses unless it can be demonstrated that:

- **the proposed location is essential to the business and that it could not be located elsewhere, and,**
- **it does not adversely affect the vitality and viability of existing centres, and;**
- **it complements existing service and facility provision in the settlement and surrounding area without generating new unsustainable transport patterns.**

Purpose

- o Providing for the expansion of existing businesses
- o Providing for businesses requiring specific and/or bespoke premises

Assumptions

- o Employment development should be accommodated on existing allocated employment land unless there is a sound reason why it should be located elsewhere.
- o Sometimes, when other options have been tested and rejected, Greenfield sites may be the most appropriate choice for new employment development.

Justification

- o It can be more attractive to develop a business on a new unallocated site elsewhere, however this may have the effect of undermining the success of existing business areas, causing harm to the local economy.
- o Whilst the first choice for new employment proposals from the community's point of view will generally be existing employment land, there are occasions when the requirements for a new business, or one needing to expand, cannot be accommodated on existing employment sites. In such cases it can be the best economic option for the local economy to seek to accommodate the business on a greenfield site subject to the safeguards set out in the policy.
- o Priority will be given to those sites and land identified as being available and suitable for employment uses identified through the Employment Land Review, they are consistent with other policies within the Local Plan and, they meet the requirements of the NPPF.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 10, 15, 37, 50, 70, 108, 124 and, 126.

POLICY EC4: HOME-BASED BUSINESS ACTIVITIES

Development proposals for new or intensification of existing employment generating activities within residential properties, will be permitted where the essentially residential character of the building and area is maintained by:

- **limiting the type and level of activity, including the hours of work and deliveries, to that consistent with the residential amenity of the area, and;**
- **preventing any harmful intensification.**

Purpose

- o The policy recognises the importance to the West Somerset economy of the substantial number of small home based businesses in the area.
- o It encourages such development subject to their adverse impact being contained at an acceptable level for a residential area, making clear that should environmental impact levels become unacceptable a business would have to either remedy the situation or relocate.

Assumptions

- o That many businesses would not start up at all without the possibility of beginning at home.
- o Many of these businesses can operate successfully and in an acceptable manner without expanding further,
- o they provide a helpful broadening of the West Somerset economy
- o Some of them provide high incomes for their owners.

Justification

- o A healthy economy requires a varied range of business premises, including provision for those businesses based in residential properties.
- o Given the remote rural nature of West Somerset and the high quality of its environment small high value home based businesses are attracted to the area.
- o In the context of the low average income levels in the West Somerset economy, home based businesses can offer an element of higher income employment helping to broaden the economy.

- o Where subsequent intensification of the employment activity results in an unacceptable level of adverse impact on the residential amenity of the area, the business would be expected to reduce the impact of its increased activities. Alternatively, the relocation of the business to more appropriate premises would be supported.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 37, 75, 108 and, 124.

POLICY EC5: SAFEGUARDING EXISTING EMPLOYMENT USES

Sites and premises with existing commercial activities will be safeguarded against change of use to residential or other non-employment generating uses unless it can be demonstrated that:

- the activity is no longer appropriate or sustainable in that location,
- the business is no longer viable in that location,
- the business/site has been marketed (at a competitive price for comparable uses) for a minimum of twelve months and has generated no interest, and, where appropriate,
- it must be demonstrated that any new use proposed would not prejudice adjacent existing or proposed uses, and;
- the new use will result in a reduction in undesirable transport movements to the location over minor roads linking it to the national primary and county highway principal route network.

Consideration will also be taken account of businesses relocating from the site/premises to more sustainable locations nearby.

Purpose

- o To protect existing employment land from redevelopment for other, potentially higher value land uses.

Assumptions

- o That the provision of employment uses in particular locations has led to employees tending to live within a convenient distance of their place of employment
- o That if an employment use is lost, the former employees are likely to have to travel further to find alternative work, or to leave the area altogether or become unemployed.

Justification

- o The provision of jobs within West Somerset's communities is not sufficient in quantity or variety to encourage enough people of working age to stay and

work within the area.

- o It is therefore essential to retain what employment uses there are, as well as encouraging new ones in order to maintain a balance of land uses which is essential to maximising self-containment within the local area.
- o The erosion of employment uses changing to other land uses will tend to harm the local economy, suitable alternative sites are more likely to be developed for other uses rather than becoming new employment land. A change of use away from employment could prejudice uses of adjacent land, or adjacent land allocated in the Local Plan for other uses which conflict with the new use to the detriment of the Local Plan strategy.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 37, 70, 108 and, 124.

POLICY EC6: WORK/LIVE DEVELOPMENTS

Proposals for work/live developments through new build or conversion of existing buildings will be supported where:

- the employment and residential elements are integrated with one another and cannot be separated or sold off as separate units and activities at a subsequent point in time,
- there would be no adverse impact upon the vitality and viability of existing employment provision within the settlement or in neighbouring settlements, and;
- there is no generation of significant additional traffic movements to and from the premises as a result of the new business activity.

New-build work/live units will only be permitted in the open countryside where it can be demonstrated that the need to be in such a location is essential to the business activity and it cannot be provided elsewhere.

Purpose

- o To encourage the development of viable work/live accommodation which will remain work/live in the long term.

Assumptions

- o That work/live accommodation is a legitimate type of employment premises which will help to encourage the formation of new businesses within the area, which;

- o Will help to broaden the West Somerset economy, and; That work/live accommodation can provide the opportunity to work and live in the same location thereby reducing transport demand.

Justification

- o Properly designed work/live accommodation should ensure that the two types of use are integrated in such a way that they cannot be split up and used separately. It is another legitimate form of employment accommodation which should attract small scale high value businesses to the area, which would work well in conjunction with super-fast broadband to become a valuable element of business premises in the District.
- o Work/live accommodation should, wherever possible, be sited within or adjacent to existing settlements in accordance with the policies of the Local Plan for residential development in order to maximise its sustainability impact.
- o Work/live development may also be created through the conversion of traditional buildings in the open countryside.
- o Work/live planning permissions would be conditioned to the effect that they remain as such.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 37, 75, 108 and, 124.

POLICY EC7: TRAINING AND EDUCATIONAL PROVISION

Proposals which strengthen the range and quality of training opportunities offered within the area will be supported.

Development proposals that combine education, training and, employment functions and opportunities in one location will be supported provided that they do not adversely affect the vitality and viability of existing centres.

Purpose

- o To take advantage of opportunities which arise to increase the range and / or skill level of the local workforce through training.

Assumptions

- o That increasing the skill levels amongst the local workforce should improve its attractiveness to potential employers and, provided that they remain resident in the area is likely to increase the amount of money circulating in the local economy.

Justification

- o Increasing skill levels in the local community should help to increase earnings and the attractiveness of the area to potential employers.
- o Additionally, major projects including the Hinkley Point new nuclear proposals offer the opportunity for local people to acquire skills which will enable them to participate as part of the workforce.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 36, 37, 53, 120 and, 124

POLICY EC8: TOURISM IN SETTLEMENTS

Tourism development which increases the range of open air and wet weather attractions/activities within existing settlements will be encouraged subject to an appropriate location for the use proposed and appropriate proposals for the management of:

- parking,
- amenity impact, and;
- accessibility,

Subject to the provisions of clauses A to E of Policy SC1.

Purpose

- o The policy seeks to encourage the provision of additional tourist attractions within existing settlements.

Assumptions

- o That providing additional tourist attractions and activities will encourage more tourists to visit the area, and will result in those who do come spending more money during their stay.

Justification

- o The policy for tourism will encourage both the consolidation of existing facilities together with a broadening of the range of activities and opportunities available to visitors
- o This will include the emphasised promotion of Minehead as a centre for visiting Exmoor and an increased profile for outdoor pursuits.
- o Some kinds of tourism development may constitute bad neighbour development with adverse impact on the amenity of neighbouring properties, it should be demonstrated that the development proposed is not likely to have such adverse impact.

See also transport Policy TR2

Definition:

Settlement:

In the context of this policy, 'settlement' means Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet, Williton and the Primary and Secondary Villages as identified in Policy SC1.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 5, 13, 14, 15, 21, 36, 37, 53, 120 and, 124

POLICY EC9: TOURISM OUTSIDE OF SETTLEMENTS

Tourism developments outside settlements will only be supported where it can be demonstrated that;

- **the proposed location is essential to the business and that it could not be located elsewhere, and;**
- **it does not adversely affect the vitality and viability of the neighbouring settlements, and;**
- **it complements existing tourism service and facility provision in neighbouring settlements and surrounding area without generating new unsustainable transport patterns.**

Purpose

- o The policy seeks to allow for the provision of additional tourist attractions outside existing settlements subject to environmental and viability safeguards.

Assumptions

- o That providing additional tourist attractions and activities will encourage more tourists to visit the area, and will result in those who do come spending more money during their stay.

Justification

- o The policy for tourism will encourage both the consolidation of existing facilities together with a broadening of the range of activities and opportunities available to visitors
- o This will include the emphasised promotion of Minehead as a centre for visiting Exmoor and an increased profile for outdoor pursuits.

See also transport Policy TR2

Definition:

Settlement:

In the context of this policy, 'settlement' means Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet, Williton and the Primary and Secondary Villages as identified in Policy SC1.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 36, 37, 119 and, 126

POLICY EC10: GATEWAY SETTLEMENTS

Tourism development proposals which enhance Minehead's role as a gateway centre for visiting Exmoor and Watchet and Williton's role as gateway settlements for the Quantock Hills and the Brendon Hills will be supported.

Purpose

- o To enhance the role of West Somerset's main communities as gateways for visiting the hill and upland areas locally.

Assumptions

- o Many visitors to Exmoor, the Quantock Hills and the Brendon Hills arrive by road from the north or east via the A39 or A358.
- o Drawing attention of visitors to the scenic and recreational attractions of these upland areas will benefit the West Somerset economy by encouraging them to stay longer, spend more and have a better experience of visiting the area.
- o Seeing more of the attractive local landscape may encourage repeat visiting.

Justification

- o The tourism industry is one of West Somerset's most important business sectors. Competition with other tourist destinations (in the south west particularly) is strong. It is therefore important to raise the profile of the area as an enjoyable place to visit. The raising of the profile of Minehead, Watchet and Williton as gateways should help to make access to these areas clearer to tourists.
- o The policy for tourism will encourage both the consolidation of existing facilities together with a broadening of the range of activities and opportunities available to visitors.
- o This will include the emphasised promotion of Minehead as a centre for visiting Exmoor and an increased profile for outdoor pursuits.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 36 and, 37.

POLICY EC11: AGRICULTURE

Development proposals for farm diversification which help to support the local agricultural economy will be supported where it does not conflict with sustainability considerations.

Purpose

- o To encourage appropriate farm diversification supporting agricultural businesses e.g.; for wood fuel production, the local production of food and, where appropriate, for sustainable tourism.

Assumptions

- o That farm diversification is a positive means of supporting the agricultural sector which can also provide an increased range of services, including employment and tourism facilities.
- o Producing, marketing and consuming food locally is beneficial in terms of minimising carbon dioxide production.

Justification

- o Farm diversification has a track record of helping to sustain farm businesses by adding non-agricultural enterprises to their portfolios. It is desirable to maintain a healthy agricultural sector for employment, land management, nature conservation and food production reasons.
- o NPPF Paragraph 28 sets out national policy.
- o It is important that in developing farm diversification schemes, the objectives of sustainable development are addressed in order to minimise adverse impacts.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 4, 7, 8, 15, 36 and, 37.

POLICY EC12: MINEHEAD PRIMARY RETAIL AREA AND CENTRAL AREAS FOR ALCOMBE, WATCHET AND WILLITON

- 1. Within the Minehead primary retail area, as defined on the policies map, business activities will be restricted to retail and retail-related activities in the A-class uses (excluding A2) at ground floor level. Other retail and retail related activities will be permitted in addition to these in the secondary retail area as defined on the Policies Map.**
- 2. Within the Alcombe, Watchet and Williton retail areas, as defined on the Policies Map, business activities of retail and retail related activities in all the A-class uses will be the preferred use at ground floor level.**

Purpose

- o To identify the extent of the main commercial retail areas of the main settlements and the activities permitted within each.

Assumptions

- o Minehead town centre is an important focus for shopping for the town and the surrounding villages on account of the relative remoteness and limited transport access to larger settlements outside of West Somerset.
- o The overall development strategy of the Local Plan requires identification and protection of existing economic and shopping services and facilities that can provide the opportunities for existing and future residents to adopt more sustainable lifestyles.
- o The absence of any significant proposed improvements to the transport networks within the West Somerset area will provide the opportunities for the existing centres to consolidate and enhance their economic vitality and viability.

Justification

- o Minehead has a well-established town centre providing a wide range of retail and retail related businesses and services.
- o Minehead performs a dual role in terms of retail activities, being both an important local shopping centre and a tourist resort.
- o Alcombe acts as an important local centre with a range of shopping and related facilities meeting the essential day-to-day needs for the south-eastern part of the Minehead urban area.

- o Within the Minehead Secondary Retail area A2 financial and professional services, D2 – leisure and a range of sui generis uses such as amusement centres, laundrettes and car showrooms may also be appropriate in addition to the main retail uses.
- o Watchet acts as an important local centre with a range of shopping and related facilities meeting the essential day-to-day needs for the residents of the town.
- o Williton acts as an important local centre with a range of shopping and related facilities meeting the essential day-to-day needs for the residents of the village.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17 and, 108.

TRANSPORT, COMMUNITY & HEALTH

POLICY TR1: ACCESS TO AND FROM WEST SOMERSET

Proposals for development must encourage the use of sustainable modes of transport within and between West Somerset's communities and travel to and from communities outside the local plan area through the provision of travel plans, travel plan statements or measures-only travel statements in accordance with the current thresholds adopted by Somerset County Council.

Purpose

- o To maintain and where possible strengthen the existing public transport services linking West Somerset's settlements with larger centres to the west and south. In particular better bus services to Bridgwater are needed
- o To maximise the potential which exists for increasing the attractiveness of and facilities for walking and cycling as a means of transport, particularly in the main settlements.
- o To provide for road improvements where these are necessitated by and can be funded through development proposals.
- o To support the West Somerset Railway through development proposals which relate to it.

Assumptions

- o It is helpful to provide as good a range of bus services as possible in order to provide non-private car based access to other settlements within West Somerset and larger service centres elsewhere such as Taunton and Bridgwater.
- o Major highway improvements are desirable, but are not usually achievable due to the high cost of improving roads such as the A39 and A358 and the lack of funding for such projects which is unlikely to improve during the plan period.
- o Whilst walking and cycling have limited potential in much of West Somerset, the larger settlements do have greater potential, particularly if improvements in existing networks are facilitated in the course of making provision for new development.
- o Walking and cycling have considerable health benefits.
- o Encouraging the increasing use of non-private car modes of transport where possible is a good thing and helps to reduce carbon dioxide emissions.

Justification

- o Proposals for development in West Somerset's communities should provide for contributions towards public transport services linking the main communities of Watchet Williton and Minehead with particularly Taunton and Bridgwater in order to provide an alternative to the private car, or for those without access to a car.
- o West Somerset has a higher than average per-capita carbon dioxide emission level, any positive change in the proportion of journeys made by non-private car modes should help improve this situation.

- o Somerset County Council's current travel plan thresholds:

Full travel plans are required above the following floorspace/dwelling number thresholds (August 2014):

800m ²	- A1 (non-food 1500m ²)
1500 m ²	- B1
2500 m ²	- B2
5000 m ²	- B8
50 dwellings	- C3

Travel plan statements:

500 m ²	- A1
1000 m ²	- B1
1500 m ²	- B2
2000 m ²	- B8
30 dwellings	- C3

Measures-only travel statements:

100 m ²	- A1
500 m ²	- B1
1000 m ²	- B2
1000 m ²	- B8
10 dwellings	- C3

- o Further explanations/caveats and other use types are covered in Somerset County Council's Travel Planning Guidance. Which can be downloaded at:

www.somerset.gov.uk/waste-planning-and-land/travel-plans/

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 17, 36, 37 and, 98.

POLICY TR2: REDUCING RELIANCE ON THE PRIVATE CAR.

Development should be located and designed to maximise the attractiveness of modes of transport other than the private car where:

- **it complements existing service and facility provision in the settlement and surrounding area without generating new unsustainable transport patterns (as a consequence), and;**
- **does not generate significant additional traffic movements over minor roads to the national primary and county highway route network.**

Purpose

- o The policy is designed to minimise additional transport demand arising from new development and to maximise modal choice within the limitations of public transport provision within the area.

Assumptions

- o That it is beneficial to locate new development where there is a choice of modes of transport available to access a varied range of destinations and facilities which would be frequently visited by inhabitants of the new development.

Justification

- o New planned development should be located insofar as is possible to maximise the choice of modes of transport available to residents. It is recognised that in planning for the continuing health of the District's rural settlements opportunities for the use of modes other than the private car are very limited.
- o This effectively means that, if possible, they should have convenient access to the bus services between Minehead and Taunton, or Minehead and Bridgwater.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 2, 15, 17, 36, 37 and 98.

POLICY CF1: MAXIMISING ACCESS TO HEALTH, SPORT, RECREATION AND, CULTURAL FACILITIES

The provision of new, and improvement of existing, health, sport, recreation and cultural facilities will be supported, where this helps to strengthen and or enhance a balanced range of provision for local communities and visiting tourists.

The unnecessary loss of valued services and facilities should be prevented, particularly where this would reduce the community's ability to meet its day to day needs.

Where a development proposal would result in the loss of such facilities, equivalent or greater replacement facilities serving the same area must be provided as part of the proposals.

The appropriate provision of formal sports facilities and/ or informal public amenity open-space/play-space will be required as an integral part of new development.

Purpose

- o To ensure that, where practical, opportunities for the shared use of existing sport and recreation facilities are maximised, particularly through the use of contributions from new development which may help to bring about improved capacity and or quality.
- o Unmet need for facilities for young people will be addressed to some extent as part of the policy for improved provision of sport and recreation facilities.
- o The flexibility of use of planning obligations monies is an important issue.

Assumptions

- o The provision of sufficient sport, recreation and cultural facilities accessible to the local community makes a positive contribution to the population's quality of life, and also to its physical and mental health.

Justification

- o It is reasonable for new development to make appropriate provision for additional sport, recreation and cultural facilities proportionate to the additional population which they will give rise to.
- o Modern lifestyles are increasingly sedentary, both in work and home life, in order to counter the adverse health impacts of the lack of exercise experienced by many, it is essential to provide the facilities to enable team games and general informal recreation involving activities such as walking and or active play.

- o Similarly, the provision of cultural facilities is also beneficial to the community, both through participation in performance and as an audience, all of which is helpful in strengthening community identity and pride as well as giving people great enjoyment.
- o The West Somerset Sport and Recreation Facilities Study March 2012 provides evidence about the levels of provision of various types of recreational facility within the area. This will be used to evidence appropriate levels of provision in new development and also for the creation of development management policies.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 22, 25, 81, 85, 86 and, 116.

POLICY CF2: PLANNING FOR HEALTHY COMMUNITIES

In order to help address the causes of ill health and maximise the benefit which spatial planning can provide in shaping healthy communities, development proposals should be designed in order to maximise the attractiveness of walking and cycling as means of making journeys to local services and facilities, and also to encourage recreational walking and cycling. Provision for disability access is also to be encouraged.

A health impact assessment will be required for all strategic development proposals.

Purpose

- o To help ensure that implementing the Local Plan's strategy and other major development contributes to improving public health within the area.

Assumptions

- o Well-designed development can encourage people using it to walk and cycle more both as a means of transport and for recreational purposes.
- o Walking and cycling more benefits peoples' general health.

Justification

Designing development so that walking and cycling become more attractive means of transport to local facilities, and also are more attractive as a recreational activity is likely to have a positive impact upon the health of the area's population.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 22, 81, 85 and, 115.

CLIMATE CHANGE

POLICY CC1: CARBON REDUCTION – NON-WIND ENERGY GENERATING SCHEMES

Energy generating development proposals (other than those for wind turbines) will be supported where:

- **they respect the local natural environment in which they are located;**
- **they respect the local historic environment and the significance of any designated and identified potential heritage assets within and neighbouring it; and,**
- **they respect the positive economic and social characteristics of communities affected especially those neighbouring them; and,**
- **adequate measures are taken to mitigate the cultural, economic, environmental and social impact of any related development on the communities affected, both in the short and the longer term.**

Purpose

- o The policy seeks to ensure that appropriate mitigation of adverse impacts and optimisation of beneficial impacts arising from energy generating proposals is provided.
- o This policy does not apply to development covered by the NSIP process and to which a DCO applies.
- o To encourage the development of low and/or zero carbon economy proposals in the area and to encourage low energy solutions in new development.

Assumptions

- o Energy generating proposals can give rise to a range of both positive and negative impacts depending on the nature of the energy generating technology involved and the scale, location and design of the scheme;
- o Some of these impacts may be on a very significant scale,
- o They will range in timescale between short and long term.
- o Where the impact is more than substantial and cannot be adequately mitigated then it will need to be demonstrated that the public benefit arising from the development clearly outweighs the consequential diminution of the asset.
- o That the development of a low and/or zero carbon energy supply chain and businesses which make use of its products would help to reduce the high per-capita carbon footprint for West Somerset.

- o It would be beneficial for residents and the environment to have low energy systems installed in their homes.
- o Climate change impact is likely to have serious implications for the low-lying coastal areas of West Somerset, and also the erosion vulnerable coastal cliffs.

Justification

- o The encouragement of local low/zero carbon energy systems will help to address climate change issues which are likely to impact adversely in West Somerset in the medium to long term.
- o The development of commercial wood fuel systems as well as the installation of CHP and wood-fuel systems in new and existing development will be a positive contribution to reducing carbon dioxide emissions.
- o It will also help to broaden the economy.
- o It will help to reduce fuel poverty due to the inaccessibility of much of the District to mains gas.
- o The search for new and more sustainable energy generating capacity has led to the development of novel technologies such as large scale photovoltaic arrays and windfarms. All energy generating facilities have locational requirements related to the nature of the energy source being captured.
- o The desire for more low carbon energy generation has led to more large scale generating development away from traditional sources of hydrocarbon energy such as the coalfields. Wind, hydro, biomass and solar energy schemes are frequently located in remote rural areas of high landscape and or ecological value, great care is necessary in order to balance the benefits of low or zero carbon energy generation with the appropriate level of protection for highly valued environments. These will also have to be considered in the context of the provisions of Policies NH2 and NH3 where appropriate.
- o A Renewable Energy Potential Study forms part of the evidence base.
- o Developments affecting the local historic environment and any designated (e.g. Listed Buildings, Scheduled Ancient Monuments, Conservation Areas, etc.) and identified potential (e.g. Areas of High Archaeological Potential – AHAP's) heritage assets within and surrounding the area will also have to be considered in the context of the provisions of Policies NH1, NH1a, NH1b and NH1x where appropriate.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 28, 29, 30, 31, 64, 107 and, 113.

POLICY CC2: FLOOD RISK MANAGEMENT

Development proposals should be located so as to mitigate against, and to avoid increased flood risk elsewhere, whilst helping to provide for the development needs of the community in accordance with the flood risk management sequential test, and where appropriate, the application of the flood risk management exception test.

Development must be designed to mitigate any adverse flooding impact which would arise from its implementation, and where possible should contribute towards the resolution of existing flooding issues.

Purpose

- o To protect new development from flood risk and existing development from additional flood risk as the result of development.

Assumptions

- o That flood risk to new and existing development should be addressed through flood risk assessment and sustainable drainage systems design features in accordance with the provisions of NPPG.

Justification

- o Flooding presents a serious risk to the social and economic health of communities, steps to minimise the risk of flooding of new, and, where possible, existing development have a very significant benefit.
- o Strategic Flood Risk Assessment Levels 1 and 2 give information on flood risk within the plan area, and particularly around the three major settlements. These provide a starting point for site specific flood risk assessment.
- o The policy applies the flood risk management provisions set out in NPPF Paragraph 100.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 72, 92 and, 93.

POLICY CC3: COASTAL CHANGE MANAGEMENT AREA

Development within the coastal change management areas, as defined on the policies map, will be limited to temporary, tourism-related development.

No development will be permitted within parts of the coastal change management area which are vulnerable to rapid coastal erosion.

Exceptionally, where the use of such development locations are necessary for sustainable development purposes, other types of development may be permitted where they would be protected by new or existing sea defences which are to be maintained in the long term.

Purpose

- o To protect new and, where possible, existing development from flood risk arising from increasing sea levels and the effects of coastal erosion in accordance with the provisions of the NPPG

Assumptions

- o That the effects of climate change include rising sea levels and increased storm violence giving rise to a greater flood risk from the sea.
- o This changing situation poses an increasing threat to new and existing development close to the parts of the coast which are low-lying and / or which are unstable and vulnerable to rapid erosion.

Justification

- o Rising sea levels in the long term and more violent storms in the short to medium term mean that policy for the management of the coastal zone – including Coastal Change Management Areas are necessary in order to minimise the damage to new development from coastal erosion and flooding. The requirements of the tourism industry, which forms an important part of the local economy, include development to provide services to visitors to the area in locations by the sea. It is advantageous to be able to provide such development on the understanding that it may not be tenable in the long term.
- o A policy of managed realignment has been put forward as part of the proposals of the draft Shoreline Management Plan for parts of the coast within the plan area.
- o The requirements of achieving sustainable development may, exceptionally, justify the development of land within the Coastal Change Management Area provided that it will be protected from flooding by new or existing sea defences and appropriate site ground levels.

- o Shoreline Management Plan 2 for the area identifies a favoured management approach for each part of the plan area coastline. Although not having received final signoff from the Environment Agency, the final draft includes proposals for the creation of secondary lines of coastal defence in two areas as part of a policy of managed realignment. These lines have been used to define the draft Coastal Change Management Areas to be shown on the Policies Map.
- o The first of these provisional secondary coastal defence lines lies between Minehead and Blue Anchor, running to the north of the West Somerset Railway from Blue Anchor as far as the boundary of Butlins holiday centre, which is also protected by the new line of defence, and then joining onto the seafront sea defence wall (see Fig 8).
- o The second area lies within Stogursey parish between Hinkley Point and Steart, approximating to the area proposed for compensatory salt marsh and intertidal mud flat creation by the Bristol Port Company (see Fig. 9).

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 44, 51 and, 52.

POLICY CC4: COASTAL ZONE PROTECTION

Development within the coastal zone and outside of settlements where the plan's policies provide for development will only be permitted for uses and activities for which a coastal location is essential and they cannot be located elsewhere. Account will be taken of;

- impact on the coastal environment,
- scale of the development,
- cumulative impact on surrounding land and property, and,
- measures taken to minimise and mitigate these matters.

Purpose

- o To protect the undeveloped coastal landscape from inessential development which would be damaging to its character.

Assumptions

- o The natural beauty of the coast is vulnerable to damage from development.
- o The natural beauty of the coast is an essential asset to the tourism industry in the area.
- o The part of the tourism industry relating to seaside tourism activities needs to develop some tourism related facilities in that sensitive environment.

- o Careful planning, siting mitigation measures etc. can often allow such development to take place without inflicting unacceptable damage on the coastal environment.
- o Some types of development are not likely to be acceptable within the coastal zone due to their scale and / or impact on the environment.

Justification

- o The attractive landscape of the relatively undeveloped parts of the coastal zone within the Local Plan area is an essential factor in driving West Somerset's tourism industry. It is therefore important to ensure that this area retains its attractiveness.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 44, 51 and, 52.

POLICY CC5: WATER EFFICIENCY

The design of development schemes which include measures to economise on the use of water supplies will be encouraged.

Purpose

- o To encourage the efficient use of water, including measures such as rainwater harvesting, greywater recycling etc.

Assumptions

- o Water is a precious resource, for which demand is increasing.
- o Climate change is likely to increase the incidence of drought in the future.

Justification

- o The situation of increasing demand, and increasing uncertainty of supply justifies the encouragement of the inclusion of measures to use water more efficiently in the design of development schemes.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 45 and, 64

POLICY CC6: WATER MANAGEMENT

Development that would have an adverse impact on:

- the availability and use of existing water resources;
- the existing water table level
- accessibility to existing watercourses for maintenance and,
- areas at risk of flooding by tidal, fluvial and/or surface water run-off

Will only be permitted if adequate and environmentally acceptable measures are incorporated that provide suitable protection and mitigation both on-site and through displacement to adjoining land.

Purpose

- o To ensure that appropriate protection is provided for water resources in the environment in the design and implementation of development.
- o To provide for maintenance of existing watercourses in development and appropriate mitigation of flood risk.

Assumptions

- o Water is a precious resource which can be damaged through poorly designed development.
- o Proper access to watercourses for the purposes of maintenance is important for the management of flood risk and biodiversity.
- o The failure to properly manage surface water runoff from development can have an adverse impact on the flood risk of lower lying land.

Justification

- o Water is an essential resource to allow life to continue, it is a valuable resource which the effects of climate change are threatening to disrupt. If badly managed, water or the lack of it can become a destructive force, either through flooding or drought for instance. Climate change impacts include the increased frequency of extreme weather events and more variable weather patterns, bringing either too much water in a short period, or not enough.
- o The effective safeguarding of groundwater. Watercourses, and the proper management of surface water runoff are key to maximising the benefits and minimising the dangers of water to the community.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 45, 64 and, 72.

ENVIRONMENT

POLICY NH1: HISTORIC ENVIRONMENT

Proposals for development should sustain and/or enhance the historic rural urban and coastal heritage of the district whilst contributing appropriately to the regeneration of the district's communities, particularly those elements which contribute to the areas distinctive character and sense of place:

- 1. Proposals will be supported where the historic environment and heritage assets and their settings are sustained and/or enhanced in line with their interest and significance. Planning decisions will have regard to the contribution heritage assets can have to the delivery of wider social, cultural, economic and environmental objectives.**
- 2. Elements of the historic environment which contribute towards the unique identity of areas and help create a sense of place will be sustained and, where appropriate, enhanced.**

Purpose

- o To conserve and enhance the built and historic environment and the heritage assets within the area that comprise it, in such a way that they continue to contribute positively to the communities' sense of identity and their attractiveness for residents and visitors.

Assumptions

- o That the archaeology, historic buildings, historic settlements and historic landscape features are a finite and irreplaceable resource of immense value to the national and local cultural heritage.
- o These heritage assets that contribute to the local historic environment play an important role in giving the area its distinctive character and its cultural identity.
- o They have a significant economic value in terms of helping to attract tourists to the area.

Justification

- o The heritage assets that make up the local historic environment of the area are unique and irreplaceable. Their cultural importance forming an essential part of the area's identity and sense of place.
- o The historic environment is also of considerable economic importance within the area. This is of benefit in helping to attract tourists to the area, but also in making it a desirable area for the location of certain types of small business which do not rely upon ease of access to the national highway network as an

important locational factor.

- o Well designed and sited development proposals can protect and enhance the historic environment and its heritage assets, conversely, poorly designed or located development can result in harm to, or loss of, heritage assets. It is therefore essential to ensure that heritage assets are properly considered when making development management decisions and in the consideration and design of development schemes. Development proposals affecting the historic environment and its heritage asset components would also need to take account of the relevant provisions in Policies NH2, NH3 and/or, NH4 as appropriate.
- o A definition of items qualifying as heritage assets is provided in the Glossary of the NPPF. Some of the heritage assets of particular note within the plan area are:
 - The late Victorian seaside resort of Minehead,
 - The historic port of Watchet,
 - The designated conservation areas,
 - The setting of Dunster Castle,
 - The West Somerset Railway, and;
 - The remains of the West Somerset Mineral Railway.
 - Registered Parks and Gardens including; St. Audries/West Quantoxhead Landscape Park, Fairfield House Deer Park and, Crowcombe Park,
 - Scheduled Ancient Monuments including; the impressive upstanding mediaeval remains of Cleeve Abbey, Stogursey Castle, the Bronze-Age barrow cemetery at Battlegore in Williton and, the iron-age hillfort of Trendle Ring.
 - Plus undesignated heritage assets of high importance.
- o Prior to submission of any development proposals, it is advised that the Somerset Historic Environment Record (Somerset HER) facility held by South West Heritage Trust is consulted in order to establish whether any important national, regional or local heritage assets and/or their setting could be affected by it.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15,b 17, 23, 38, 62, 63, 97, 101 and, 124.

POLICY NH2: MANAGEMENT OF HERITAGE ASSETS

Development proposals that;

- A. Are likely to affect the significance of a heritage asset, including the contribution made to its setting should demonstrate an appropriately evidenced understanding of the significance in sufficient detail to allow the potential impacts to be adequately assessed.**
- B. Demonstrate a sympathetic and creative re-use and adaptation of historic buildings will be encouraged.**
- C. Affect a conservation area should preserve or enhance its character or appearance, especially those elements identified in any conservation area appraisal.**
- D. Will help to secure a sustainable future for West Somerset's heritage assets, especially those identified as being at greatest risk of loss or decay, will be supported.**
- E. Result in an agreed material change to a heritage asset should be accompanied by recording and interpretation, undertaken in order to document and understand the asset's archaeological, architectural, artistic and/or historic significance with the scope of the recording being proportionate to the asset's significance and the impact of the development upon it. The information should be made publically available through the historic environment record.**

Purpose

- o To conserve and enhance the built and historic environment and the heritage assets that comprise it, in such a way that they continue to contribute positively to the communities' sense of identity and their attractiveness for residents and visitors.

Assumptions

- o That the heritage assets and the historic landscape features are a finite and irreplaceable resource of immense cultural value at both the national and local level.
- o These heritage assets contribute to the local historic environment and play an important role in giving the area its distinctive character and its cultural identity.
- o They have a significant economic value in terms of helping to attract tourists to the area.

- o A definition of items qualifying as heritage assets is provided in the Glossary of the NPPF. Designated heritage assets can include Listed Buildings, buildings within Conservation Areas and, structures identified on a Historic Environment Record held by South West Heritage Trust.

Justification

- o The heritage assets that comprise the historic environment of West Somerset contribute, along with the local landscape in making the area an attractive place to live and visit.
- o The heritage assets that make up the local historic environment of the area are unique and irreplaceable. Their cultural importance forming an essential part of the area's identity and sense of place.
- o The historic environment and its heritage assets components are also of considerable economic importance within the area, because of the contribution they make to the area's attractiveness.
- o Well designed and sited development proposals can protect and enhance the historic environment and its heritage assets, conversely, poorly designed or located development can result in significant damage to, or loss of, heritage assets. It is therefore essential to ensure that heritage assets are properly considered when making development management decisions and in the consideration and design of development schemes. Development proposals affecting the historic environment and its heritage asset components would also need to take account of the relevant provisions in Policies NH1, NH3 and/or, NH4 as appropriate.
- o Where a development proposal is likely to affect the significance of a heritage asset and its setting, the understanding of the significance the proposed change and the justification for it. This should be informed by available evidence, desk-based evaluations and, where appropriate, further site investigation to establish the significance of both known and/or any potential heritage assets that might be affected.
- o Where a development proposal affects a heritage asset in such a way that it the existing format is likely to be changed, irretrievably lost or, hidden, it is necessary to ensure that a complete record and associated interpretation of it is made before such works commence. The information and understanding gained through this recording process should be made publicly available through an appropriate update of any existing Historical Environment Record (HER) or creation of a new record as a minimum. Also, where appropriate, at the asset itself through on-site interpretation.
- o A variety of approaches will be used to assist in the protection and enjoyment of the historic environment including:

- the use of appraisals and management plans of existing and potential conservation areas
- taking opportunities for removing assets from the at risk register,
- considering the use of article 4 directions,
- working with partners, owners and developers to identify ways to positively manage and make better use of historic assets,
- considering improvements to the public realm and the setting of heritage assets within it,
- ensuring that information about the significance of the historic environment is publicly available,
- where there is a loss in whole or in part to the significance of an identified historic asset then evidence should be recorded of its importance, and;
- considering the need for the preparation of local evidence or plans.

Particular attention will be given to heritage assets at risk of harm or loss of significance, or where a number of heritage assets have significance as a group or give context to a wider area.

- o The local planning authority will monitor buildings or other heritage assets at risk through neglect, decay or other threats, proactively seeking solutions for assets at risk through discussions with owners and a willingness to consider positively, development schemes that would ensure the repair and maintenance of the asset and, as a last resort, using its statutory powers.
- o Prior to submission of any development proposals, it is advised that the Somerset Historic Environment Record (Somerset HER) facility held by South West Heritage Trust is consulted in order to establish whether any important national, regional or local heritage assets and/or their setting could be affected by it.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 38, 39, 40, 41, 54, 55, 56, 62, 63, 97, 101, 115 and, 124.

POLICY NH3: AREAS OF HIGH ARCHAEOLOGICAL POTENTIAL

Proposals within areas of high archaeological potential, as shown on the policies map, (or elsewhere with the potential to impact on heritage assets with archaeological interest) should be accompanied with a statement describing the significance of the heritage asset and the likely impacts on the asset. This is likely to require a desk-based assessment incorporating a settings assessment where designated assets are likely to be impacted and where appropriate a field evaluation.

Purpose

- o To ensure that the opportunity to record/protect suspected archaeological and/or heritage assets of greater than local importance is provided.

Assumptions

- o AHAP identification accords with the latest information available from Somerset Heritage and Environmental Records.

Justification

- o This Policy ensures that before any decision is made that affects a heritage asset sufficient information is submitted to ensure the decision is reasoned and based on a complete understanding of the significance of the asset as required by the NPPF paragraph 128.
- o Requirement of NPPF para. 128

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15,17, 38, 62, 63, 97, 101 and, 124.

POLICY NH4: ARCHAEOLOGICAL SITES OF LOCAL SIGNIFICANCE

Where proposals impact on sites with archaeological interest of local significance developers will ensure the investigation, recording and the advance of understanding of the significance of the asset. This information will be made publically accessible.

Purpose

- o To ensure that the opportunity to record/protect suspected archaeological and/or heritage assets of local importance is provided.

Assumptions

- o Identification accords with the latest information available from Somerset Heritage and Environmental Records or enhances local knowledge and understanding.

Justification

- o This Policy ensures that where a heritage asset is impacted the harm is mitigated through a greater understanding of the asset by investigating through excavation and/or recording of an asset, archiving of the evidence and publication of results in line with NPPF paragraph 141.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 62, 63, 97, 101 and,124.

POLICY NH5: LANDSCAPE CHARACTER PROTECTION

Within the identified landscape character areas, as shown in figure 2, development should be located and designed in such a way as to minimise adverse impact on the quality and integrity of that local landscape character area.

Purpose

- o The policy provides for the appropriate consideration of protected landscapes when considering the design of development schemes.
- o Conservation of non-statutory designated landscapes which are still high quality, i.e.: the Brendon Hills is an issue, landscape character approach can provide protection at an appropriate level through the application of the evidence in the West Somerset Landscape Character Assessment.

Assumptions

- o The care with which development is designed and sited in high quality rural landscapes makes a considerable difference to the positive or negative impact which it has on its setting.

Justification

- o Large parts of West Somerset are the subject of statutory landscape designations – the Exmoor National Park which lies outside the Local Plan area, and the Quantock Hills Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty.
- o The remainder of the District, not subject to statutory protection also contains some very high quality rural landscape, most notably the Brendon Hills in the central part of the Local Plan area.
- o The policy is not intended to restrict the principle of development beyond that expressed in the Local Plan's policies for any particular area, however it does require that the character of the area should be treated as an important factor when designing and deciding on development proposals.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 9, 15, 73, 77, 78, 90 and, 127.

POLICY NH6: NATURE CONSERVATION AND THE PROTECTION AND ENHANCEMENT OF BIODIVERSITY

Planning permission for development will be granted subject to the application demonstrating that:

- the proposed development will not generate unacceptable adverse impacts on biodiversity;
- measures will be taken to protect or mitigate to acceptable levels (or, as a last resort, proportionately compensate for) adverse impacts on biodiversity. Measures shall ensure a net gain in biodiversity where possible. The Somerset 'habitat evaluation procedure' will be used in calculating the value of a site to species affected by a proposal as appropriate. Where habitat is replaceable, mitigation techniques need to be proven;
- the local planning process will be used to protect, enhance and restore the ecological network within West Somerset. The weight of protection afforded to a site that contributes to the district's biodiversity will reflect its role in maintaining connectivity and resilience of the local ecological network; and
- a 'habitat regulations assessment' will be required for development proposed which directly affects European and internationally designated sites and for areas that ecologically support the integrity of these sites.

Purpose

- o To safeguard and enhance biodiversity.
- o The plan's clear priority is to protect existing habitat and maintain the value of other habitats. Development should avoid irreplaceable habitats and land within designated sites and where offsetting is permitted, there needs to be evidence that mitigation would be successful. Where this is not possible development should be refused.
- o To protect and enhance ecological networks. Areas of high value natural habitat often exist in isolation, which makes them vulnerable to the erosion of their interest and value. Linking such areas together to facilitate the movement of species within the wider area which helps to maintain genetic diversity and can encourage the enhancement of the natural value of other areas of linked habitat.
- o To ensure that the effects on European and international nature conservation sites outside of the designated boundaries are accounted for. All data necessary for carrying out assessment on these sites needs to be submitted with the application.

Assumptions

- o The safeguarding and enhancement of biodiversity are inherently good things for an area's community, wellbeing, economy and environment.

Justification

- o Section 40 of the Natural and Rural Communities Act 2006, places a duty on a public authority to have regard, in the exercise of their functions, to the purpose of conserving biodiversity. A key purpose of this duty is to embed consideration of biodiversity as an integral part of policy decision-making, which should be seeking to make a significant contribution to the achievement of the commitments made by Government in its Biodiversity 2020 strategy.

- o The following extract from the government's biodiversity strategy: 'Biodiversity 2020' sets out the essential justification for protecting and enhancing biodiversity through the planning process:

"Biodiversity is important for its own sake and has its own intrinsic value. A number of ground-breaking studies such as the National Ecosystems Assessment (NEA) have shown this value also goes further. It is the building block of our 'ecosystems'. These provide us with a wide range of goods and services that support our economic and social wellbeing. These include essentials such as food, fresh water and clean air, but also less obvious services such as protection from natural disasters, regulation of our climate, and purification of our water or pollination of our crops. Biodiversity also provides important cultural services, enriching our lives."

- o There are many sites within the plan area designated at European, National and local level for their nature conservation or geological / geomorphological importance. The European and national designations enjoy statutory protection, and the local sites also form an important part of the overall sum of the natural environment which warrants protection through the planning system. Areas outside the designated sites also ecologically support cited features and need to be accounted for if integrity is to be maintained (Biodiversity 2020: A strategy for England's wildlife and ecosystem services; DEFRA; 2011; Paragraph 1.1.)
- o The National Planning Policy Framework (2012) includes the following;
 - planning policies should plan for biodiversity at a landscape-scale across local authority boundaries;
 - identify and map local ecological networks, including the hierarchy of international, national and, locally designated sites, wildlife-corridors and, stepping-stones that connect them and the areas for habitat restoration or creation; and,
 - promote the preservation, restoration and, re-creation of priority habitats, ecological networks and, the protection and recovery of priority species populations.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 26, 27, 43, 87, 88, 95, 96, 99, 100, 103, 104, 105, 106, 124 and, 128.

POLICY NH7: GREEN INFRASTRUCTURE

The creation and enhancement of a green infrastructure network will be supported. Green infrastructure should be used to help protect and enhance the heritage assets of the area.

Purpose

- o To help improve the existing provision and particularly networks of green infrastructure.
- o To help provide new green infrastructure as part of development.
- o To help maintain and enhance biodiversity in the area.
- o To improve public health through increasing the attractiveness of walking.

Assumptions

- o Linking areas of high value habitat together can increase the quality and resilience of ecosystems in an area.
- o Making walking a more attractive activity is beneficial to the overall health of an area's population and in particular in respect of obesity and mental health.

Justification

- o Despite West Somerset being a mainly undeveloped area, public access to areas of greenspace for recreational purposes is not always available. The development of a network of green infrastructure can have significant health and environmental benefits by linking areas of greenspace, both of ecological and recreational value. Examples of linking features might be areas of landscaping in association with development, field margins managed for nature conservation value, cycle tracks, footpaths or, woodland planting. Stream and river corridors are a key example of green infrastructure.
 - o Recreational green infrastructure networks delivered through development can make walking a more attractive means of getting about in new areas of development and accessing nearby services. A key aim here is to maximise the value of existing public access land and footpaths by completing missing links where possible. Significant benefit can sometimes be achieved by quite small interventions to mend a 'missing link' in the existing footpath and/ or bridleway network.
 - o The public health benefits of encouraging walking both as a means of transport and for recreational purposes, and the mental health benefits of enjoying the natural environment make this an important objective of the planning process.
- Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17, 26, 27, 43, 87, 88, 95, 96, 99, 100, 103, 104, 105, 106 and, 128.

POLICY NH8:

PROTECTION OF BEST AND MOST VERSATILE AGRICULTURAL LAND

The best and most versatile agricultural land (Grades 1, 2 and 3a) will be protected from significant development proposals. Planning permission for development affecting such land will only be granted exceptionally if the presumption in favour of sustainable development outweighs the need to protect it and either:

- Sufficient land of a lower grade (Grades 3b, 4 and 5) is unavailable in an appropriate location to provide sustainable development; or
- Available lower grade land has an environmental value recognised by a statutory or non-statutory wildlife, historic or archaeological designation which outweighs the agricultural considerations.

If best and most versatile land needs to be developed and there is a choice between sites in different grades, land of the lowest grade available should be used.

Purpose

- o To ensure that the most flexible and productive agricultural land is protected from development provided that alternative land of a lower quality is available in an appropriate location.

Assumptions

- o Land with a high quality capacity to produce particularly arable crops is a scarce and valuable commodity which should, wherever possible, be protected for use for food production.

Justification

- o Food security is of increasing importance, the policy of protecting the best and most valuable agricultural land continues the approach adopted in the 1940's recognising that good quality agricultural land is a finite resource, and that it should be protected for agricultural use unless, exceptionally, sustainable development priorities strongly suggest that such land should be developed.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 17 and, 76.

POLICY NH9: POLLUTION, CONTAMINATED LAND AND LAND INSTABILITY

Development that generates atmospheric emissions which would cause harm to human health, senses or property will not be permitted and where such uses exist the local planning authority will not permit sensitive other uses within a reasonable distance of such uses.

- Proposals for development involving potential noise nuisance to existing occupiers of land or buildings will only be permitted when measures to minimise the impact of noise likely to be generated are incorporated as part of the development.
- Proposals for noise-sensitive developments, typically housing, hospitals and schools, will not be permitted where:

An unacceptable level of nuisance arises from existing sources of noise (e.g. from road traffic, railways, industrial and commercial developments, recreational and sporting activities)

There is potential for an unacceptable level of nuisance by the increase in the existing level of noise, unless appropriate noise mitigation measures are incorporated in the design of the development.

All development proposals on or in proximity to land known to be, or which may be, contaminated will include measures designed to prevent an unacceptable risk to public health and the environment.

Development proposals will not be permitted on or in close proximity to land known to be, or which may be, unstable.

Purpose

- o To avoid unmitigated pollution or nuisance from new development
- o To prevent noise sensitive new development from suffering from excessive noise,
- o To prevent new development being adversely affected by land contamination, and;
- o To prevent new development being adversely affected by unstable ground.

Assumptions

- o The users of new development should be protected from damaging levels of pollution, land contamination or land instability.

Justification

- o Pollution at unacceptable levels is damaging to human health and the natural environment. Pollution can be air or water borne, and be in the form of noise or toxins. It can be created by emissions from development, natural processes or land contamination – e.g. from old landfills. A related issue is development proposals which are affected by unstable ground. All of these are conditions which should be avoided in carrying out new development.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, and, 17.

POLICY NH10: DEVELOPMENT IN PROXIMITY TO HINKLEY POINT NUCLEAR POWER STATION

Development proposals in the consultation zones will be considered in consultation with the office for nuclear regulation (ONR), having regard to the scale of development proposed, its location, population distribution of the area and the impact on public safety, to include how the proposal would impact on local emergency planning arrangements and other planning criteria.

Consultation on planning applications will be undertaken with ONR on the basis of the table below:

ZONE	DEVELOPMENT TYPE
Inner	• Any new development, re-use or re-classification of an existing development that could lead to an increase in residential or non-residential populations thus impacting on the emergency plan. • Any new development, re-use or re-classification of an existing development that could cause an external hazard to the site.
Outer	• Any new development, re-use or re-classification that will lead to a material increase in the size of existing development, which is otherwise likely to impact on the off-site emergency plan • Any new development, re-use or re-classification that will lead to a material increase in the size of an existing development that could have an impact on the extendibility of countermeasures beyond the depz. • Any new development, re-use or re-classification of an existing development that could pose an external hazard to the site.

Purpose

- o To consider the impact of any increase in population within the areas close to Hinkley Point Power Station.

Assumptions

- o As part of managing the (very small) risk of accident involving the release of radiological material it is prudent to consider increases in population living or having other business within close proximity of nuclear sites.

Justification

- o Consultation zones are those identified by ONR and shown on the map in Appendix 2 (potential applicants are advised to contact ONR in respect of any changes to the extent of the zones shown on the map).
- o ONR provide guidance on Land Use Planning in close proximity to Nuclear Installations (www.onr.org.uk). This provides advice about the need for consultations about proposed developments in the vicinity of licensed nuclear installations.
- o Consultation with ONR supports the Government's long-standing policy objective requiring appropriate control of development around licensed nuclear sites to limit the radiological consequences to the public in the unlikely event of an accident.
- o The policy is a measure of prudence over and above the stringent regulatory requirements placed upon nuclear operators by ONR.
- o ONR when consulted will provide advice to the Council which should be considered when making decisions on planning applications within the consultation zones.
- o All new residential developments within consultation zones around Hinkley Point Power Station will be monitored and reported to ONR on an annual basis.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 16, 19 and, 32.

POLICY NH11: BAT CONSULTATION ZONE

Planning applications for development on sites within the West Somerset bat consultation zone, as shown on the Policies Map, may require a 'test of significance' under the habitat regulations to be carried out. Applicants must provide all necessary information to enable such a test to be conducted, including any necessary survey work, reports and avoidance/mitigation measures with the application.

Purpose

- o To secure the conservation objectives of the Barbastelle bat feature of the Exmoor and Quantocks Oak Woodlands SAC from effects outside of its designated boundaries

Assumptions

- o Barbastelle bat populations are affected by changes to land use up to and beyond 9 kilometres from the designated site's boundaries. These effects will not necessarily be detected or be considered in the planning process.

Justification

- o As 'competent authority' under the Conservation of Species and Habitats Regulations 2010 [the 'Habitats Regulations'] West Somerset District Council is required to carry out a 'test of likely significant effect' on planning applications that potentially affect the conservation objectives of the site. The District Council is also responsible for ensuring that populations and distribution of European Protected Species are maintained at a 'Favourable Conservation Status' as defined in Article 1 of the Habitats Directive.
- o Outcome of the Habitats Regulations Assessment of the draft Local Plan. December 2011 and Habitat Regulations Assessment of the Publication Draft Local Plan November 2014.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 17, 42, 43, 100 and, 102.

POLICY NH12: WATERFOWL CONSULTATION ZONE

Planning applications for wind energy development on sites within the West Somerset waterfowl consultation zone, as shown on the Policies Map, may require a 'test of significance' under the habitats regulations to be carried out. Applicants must provide all necessary information to enable such a test to be conducted, including any necessary survey work, reports and avoidance/mitigation measures with the application.

Purpose

- o To secure the conservation objectives for wintering and migratory bird populations and waterfowl assemblage of the Severn Estuary SPA/Ramsar from effects outside of its designated boundaries.

Assumptions

- o Some species of commuting birds including swans, geese, ducks and waders are vulnerable to collision with wind turbines.

Justification

- o As 'competent authority' under the Conservation of Species and Habitats Regulations 2010 [the 'Habitats Regulations'] West Somerset District Council is required to carry out a 'test of likely significant effect' on planning applications that potentially affect the conservation objectives of the site.
- o Outcome of the Habitats Regulations Assessment of the draft Local Plan. December 2011.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 17, 42, 43, 100 and, 102.

POLICY NH13: SECURING HIGH STANDARDS OF DESIGN

New development will be expected to meet the highest standards of design. In order to achieve this, all proposals for new development (excluding small domestic applications and changes of use) should demonstrate that where appropriate:

- An analysis of the constraints and opportunities of the site and its surroundings have informed the principles of design and how the detailed design responds positively to its neighbours and the local context;
- The proposal makes a positive contribution to the local environment and creates a place with a distinctive character;
- The public realm has been designed to ensure that it is attractive, safe, accessible and well connected to its surroundings, including walking and cycling routes to and within the development, to encourage their use in the interests of public health;
- The landscape proposals have been developed to enhance both the natural and built environment and maximise the potential to improve local biodiversity;
- Measures to minimise carbon emissions and promote renewable energy and reduce impact on climate change form an integral part of the design solutions.

Purpose

- o To ensure that new development contributes to maintaining a high quality built environment within the area, and helps to deliver sustainable development.

Assumptions

- o The provision of well-designed development appropriate to its intended purpose and context will serve to protect and enhance the high quality of the environment within West Somerset.
- o This protects the quality of life of residents, and
- o Also has a positive economic impact through maintaining the attractiveness of the area to tourists and investors.

Justification

- o The NPPF places great importance on securing high standards of design in the built environment. It states that good design is inseparable from good

planning. One of the government's prime objectives for the planning system is to promote good design that ensures attractive, usable, and durable places. This is seen as a key element in securing sustainable development.

- o The built environment within the District is diverse and of a generally high quality. It includes the historic seaside resort of Minehead, other historic market towns and villages, and other development within the countryside. The fundamental objective is therefore to ensure that new development, wherever it is located within the District, should be of the highest quality, which respects its context and enhances local character.
- o Good design is an inseparable aspect of creating sustainable communities, and is an important part of ensuring that the District makes the most effective and efficient use of developable land. It is a key indicator in assessing a community's quality of life.
- o A number of major developments are planned during the next twenty years, at Minehead/Alcombe, Watchet and Williton. These offer the opportunity to ensure that the highest standards of sustainable design are achieved, and that high quality places are created.
- o While an individual design response will be determined by the local context, it is essential that all new development should aspire to meet the highest standards of sustainable design. In order to achieve this a coherent and coordinated approach is required to ensure that the following objectives are achieved:
- o New development should create a sense of place with a distinctive character, which clearly demonstrates how it has responded to its local context. Some communities have produced Village Design Statements which help to define the character of the locality and identify important local features. Establishing local design standards could form an integral part of future neighbourhood planning; new development (which includes hard and soft landscaping) should connect seamlessly to surrounding development in terms of layout, scale, form, enclosure, space and materials and, where appropriate, take the opportunity to enhance the public realm;
- o the public realm should be designed to ensure that well connected, safe and attractive environments are created for the community, giving priority to pedestrians and cyclists and not motor vehicles where appropriate;
- o the built and natural environment should be properly integrated. The design process should therefore be holistic to ensure a well-defined transition from built-up to natural areas, particularly on the edges of settlements;

- o new development should complement but not seek to mimic existing development and should be of its time. The Council will encourage a contemporary approach to new designs which respect and respond positively to the context, local distinctiveness and sense of place in terms of layout, scale, form, space and materials;
- o measures to minimise carbon emissions, promote renewable energy and manage water effectively should be an integral part of the design solutions;
- o Developers and their agents should carry out contextual surveys and analyse their findings in accordance with the urban design principles set out in the 'By Design' documents and other relevant guidance. The analysis should inform the design concept and applicants should be able to demonstrate in their design and access statements how the urban design principles above have informed the detailed design in terms of its character, continuity and enclosure, quality of the public realm, ease of movement, adaptability and diversity.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15, 18 and, 33.

POLICY NH14: NATIONALLY DESIGNATED LANDSCAPE AREAS

Major development proposals within the Quantock Hills Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty will be determined in accordance with national planning policy.

Where development is likely to affect the Quantock Hills AONB or Exmoor National Park, regard will be had to their statutory purposes.

Applications for development should have regard to location, siting, orientation and landscaping to achieve high quality design and to ensure that the proposals conserve or enhance the natural beauty, wildlife, cultural heritage and tranquillity of the AONB or the National Park and their settings. Development which would conflict with the achievement of the statutory purposes of the AONB or the National Park, or their settings or which would adversely affect the understanding or enjoyment of the national park's special qualities, will not be permitted.

Purpose

- o To protect the high quality landscape characteristics of the Quantock Hills AONB within the West Somerset LPA area.
- o The policy provides for the appropriate consideration of protected landscapes when considering the design of development schemes.

- o The policy provides for the appropriate consideration of functional and design issues in locations outside but would impact on nationally designated areas and their associated landscape characteristics.

Assumptions

- o The care with which development is designed and sited in high quality designated rural landscapes makes a considerable difference to the positive or negative impact which it can have on the area and, on its setting.
- o Landscape impact can potentially be reduced through the careful design, location and, orientation of new development.
- o Small-scale development is not referred to directly in the context of protected landscapes. It follows that impact is generally likely to be lesser than that associated with major schemes but, nonetheless it is important to recognise that any impact should be minimised.

Justification

- o Nationally designated landscapes account for almost 75% of the West Somerset local authority area in the form of, Quantock Hills Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty (AONB) and, Exmoor National Park (ENP). West Somerset Council is the LPA for the AONB but the development within the National Park is determined by its own separate LPA, the Exmoor National Park Authority.
- o The Quantock Hills Area of Outstanding Natural Beauty (AONB) is located across three separate LPA's and there is a need for a general consistency in the planning policy approach to development within it.
- o Development in the areas outside of but surrounding/adjoining nationally designated landscape areas, can have an impact on the latter. It is an important contextual issue when dealing with development proposals within such areas and requires additional/ careful consideration as part of the development management process.
- o Where development proposals are made in locations surrounding/adjoining nationally designated landscape area, it will be assessed in the context of its impact on the designated area itself, not the setting.
- o The policy is not intended to prevent the principle of development within the AONB or, surrounding it or other nationally designated landscape areas. However, it does require that the character of such areas, should be treated as an important factor when designing and deciding on development proposals.

- o Where development is deemed to be necessary and acceptable, preference will be sought to ensure that the new-build can be successfully integrated with, either;
 - a) adjoining existing structures whether as part of the built-form of a nearby settlement or,
 - b) as part of a cluster of existing permanent buildings.
- This is so as to minimise the impact of the new-build on the surrounding area and landscape and to avoid drawing attention to the structure as a feature in the landscape in its own right.
- o Where development is considered to be necessary and acceptable, particular attention will be paid to the design taking account of; siting, scale, form, height, massing, detail and/or use of local materials as appropriate.

Definitions:

Nationally designated landscapes – those designated by the Secretary of State through relevant primary and secondary legislation e.g. Designation Order, Statutory Instrument (S.I.).

Major development – proposals for 10 or more dwellings and/or, large structures, whose intrusion on the local and surrounding landscape would be difficult to effectively mitigate through traditional screening and landscaping techniques without drawing attention to this, itself.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 9, 15, 57, 73, 77, 78, 90 and, 127.

POLICY GT1: GYPSY AND TRAVELLER SITE POLICY

Provision will be made in a local plan to meet an identified need for up to 10 gypsy and traveller pitches during the plan period. Applications for the development of gypsy and traveller accommodation will be determined in accordance with national policy.

Purpose

- o A policy to enable the provision of additional gypsy pitches identified in the Gypsy and Traveller Accommodation Assessment.

Assumptions

- o An appropriate number of residential Gypsy pitches should be provided for the number of families who are demonstrated resort or reside in the area.
- o Consideration needs to be made for potential traveller accommodation requirements where they intend to remain active in this capacity.

Justification

- o West Somerset is not identified as being on an identified route or as a regular destination for the Gypsy and Traveller communities. It does have a small community who have been accommodated for a number of years on a site near Stogursey. The site has a capacity of 10 pitches and the number in occupation varies. The 2010 survey of Gypsy and Traveller accommodation needs up to 2020 identified a possible requirement for three additional pitches arising from local demand. The Gypsy and Traveller Needs Assessment Update for Somerset published in October 2013 considered the period to the end of the plan period in 2032 for which a potential 10 additional pitches was found to be required. Given the relative uncertainty as to the exact quantum and timing of the additional requirement, the policy seeks to enable the provision of the pitches as and when the need actually arises.
- o The policy sets out a criteria-based approach to the consideration of gypsy and traveller pitch proposals. The approach outlined will be applied not just to the consideration of planning applications themselves but also through the plan-led system in assessing the suitability of potential sites for allocation in subsequent Development Plan Documents.
- o This policy has been drafted in the context of the Government's recently amended guidance on the consideration of gypsy and traveller sites and seeks to ensure that a sequential approach is taken to site selection which will enable need to be met in locations which are well-related to existing and proposed services and facilities and which minimise the need to travel.
- o The impact of development on existing communities and how well proposals can be integrated is an important consideration in the determination of applications for gypsy and traveller provision. Applicants will therefore be expected to demonstrate that proposals do not unacceptably impact upon the amenity of existing residents.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 11,12 and, 20.

ARRANGEMENTS FOR MANAGING AND MONITORING THE DELIVERY OF THE STRATEGY – IMPLEMENTATION

POLICY ID1: INFRASTRUCTURE DELIVERY

The planning and delivery of development should ensure efficient and effective use of existing infrastructure and should provide for the delivery of an appropriate level of justified new or improved transport, education, health, cultural, sport, recreation and green infrastructure in relation to the development proposed.

Purpose

- o A policy to ensure that development within the Local Plan area is implemented in accordance with the sustainable development principles of the Local Plan.
- o An Infrastructure Delivery Plan has been prepared to accompany the policy and express how it will be implemented.

Assumptions

- o That implementation of development without the necessary infrastructure investment would have a range of consequent adverse impacts upon the local area.
- o Infrastructure needs arising directly from a proposed development should be provided by the developer as part of the costs of development.

Justification

- o The Council will work in partnership with service providers, neighbouring local planning authorities and Somerset County Council to identify necessary local infrastructure requirements for the fulfilment of the strategy.
- o In order to achieve the successful implementation of the strategy, delivering the anticipated benefits to the community, it is essential that the increased infrastructure requirements arising from the proposed development are properly provided for through S106 planning agreements. Failure to address this would have the unwanted impact of overloading existing infrastructure provision, to the detriment of both existing residents and those moving into the new development.
- o It is however important that the infrastructure requirements which are specified for a scheme are proportionate, and keep in sight the fact that

development proposals must be viable in order to result in their implementation.

- o Affordable housing is also an essential part of the social infrastructure to which new development should contribute; this is addressed through policy SC4.
- o The Council's Planning Obligations Supplementary Planning Document will be revised to assist with the implementation of this policy.
- o Clear arrangements for managing and monitoring the delivery of the strategy.

Sources: See Appendix 1 nos.; 15 and, 17.

